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SC suggests steps to curb sexual offences in Delhi

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India to boost defence ties with Switzerland

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Jamil's India faces Forlan's Uruguay

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INSIDE



Brazil lurches to the right as Lula falters in election

SAO PAULO

Sunday night was supposed to be historic for Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva, who was seeking a record fourth term as Brazil's President. But when the results came in, instead of winning in the first round, Lula trailed his challenger Flávio Bolsonaro by about 1.8 percentage points, or 2.2 million votes. » PAGE 14

2 dead, 11 rescued after ship catches fire in Black Sea

BUCHAREST

Two crew died and 11 were rescued on Monday after a fire broke out on a ship in the Black Sea which later sank, Romanian authorities said. The cause of the fire was not given. The Black Sea has become a battlefield for increasing drone attacks in the Russia-Ukraine war. » PAGE 14



Sanitary napkins to be dispensed at bus depots

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

A scheme of Keralam's Women and Child Development department to make women's travel easier from the menstrual hygiene perspective, will be launched on Tuesday. Sanitary napkin vending machines, besides incinerators, will be installed at public places as part of the 100-day programme. » PAGE 3

SC distances itself from tweaks to Form 6

Plea seeks suspension of CEC over allegations of bias, unilateralism, and overreach during SIR

Court takes note of post-retirement immunity for leading poll officials, not available even to judges

Petitioner says court should at least order that EC should act unanimously during pendency of case

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday distanced itself from the controversial alterations made to Form 6 for registering new voters during the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls across several States, shifting scrutiny to the Election Commission of India (EC).

"We are making it clear, any modifications to Form 6 have not been made by us," Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, heading a three-judge Bench, said.

The oral observation was made during the hearing of two petitions demanding the suspension of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar over allegations of bias, administrative unilateralism, and procedural overreach during the SIR

process. Justice Joymalya Bagchi, part of the Bench, pointed to how the CEC and Election Commissioners continue to enjoy immunity from legal proceedings even after demitting office, a protection not available to even judges.

Senior advocate Vikas Singh, for petitioner Rakesh Singh, urged the court to suspend the CEC or divest him of any authority till the Supreme Court took a final call on the petition.

"But then, who will conduct elections? You have to file petitions keeping in mind the working of the Constitution," Justice Bagchi responded.

Mr. Singh submitted that it was a grave situation that threatened the very basis of democracy.

He requested the court to grant an interim relief on the petition, saying the

"country will burn".

He said, in the alternative, the court should at least include in its order that the poll body should take decisions unanimously during the pendency of the case.

Issuing notice, the Chief Justice said the court would act on authenticated information regarding the allegations.

"We will examine the records, look into the particular records. We would like to see some responses [from the EC] first," Chief Justice Kant said on the plea for interim orders.

Justice Bagchi added that the Supreme Court cannot be asked to "put the cart before the horse and presume that all the EC orders were issued unilaterally".

Form 6 is a statutory document provided in the Schedule of the Registration of Electors Rules,



We are making it clear, any modifications to Form 6 have not been made by us... We will examine the records, look into the particular records. We would like to see some responses [from the EC] first

SURYA KANT
Chief Justice of India

1960. Modifications to Form 6 should be done through the proper law-making process, and not by unilateral administrative actions.

The alterations in Form 6 included a supplementary declaration form on additional linkage requirements for voter registration. New applicants have to declare whether they, their parents, or their grandparents were registered in the previous SIR electoral rolls. Further, a

an Election Commissioner..." "A protection when in office is always understood. But the 'was' in the provision is perhaps only protection with regard to the President. It does not apply even to judges... Look at the Judges Inquiry Act," Justice Bagchi observed.

Senior advocate Vikas Singh, for petitioner Rakesh Singh, said the statute had "exalted the CEC to such a high position, perhaps higher than a Supreme Court judge". Mr. Singh argued that Section 18 of the 2023 Act and the Constitution gave the CEC no individual title. He was the Chairman of the multi-member Commission and not the Commission itself, the senior counsel argued.

Senior advocate Menaka Guruswamy, for petitioner Shailendra Mani Tripathi, pointed out that 30% of the electorate in Delhi and 25%

of the electorate in West Bengal have been deleted in the SIR process. She submitted that lakhs of appeals were pending before the appellate tribunals in West Bengal.

"Your Lordships had supervised that [SIR]... Now, voters have been excluded from one election cycle already. There is another election cycle going to commence... See how SIR was conducted in Delhi. Form 6 has two new conditions added. They were circulated. Under the Schedule, Form 6 cannot be modified," the senior advocate submitted. The court tagged both petitions and indicated it may list the case for next week to hear the Commission's side.

VOTERS TO MISS BYPOLLS
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ILLEGAL CHANGE: RAHUL
» PAGE 5

Harvest hues



A farmer harvests cockscomb flowers on the outskirts of Srinagar on Monday. The blooms are used for ornamental and culinary purposes. AFP

'Any further concessions on U.S. deal very difficult'

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Negotiations for the India-U.S. trade deal have reached a "plateau", where it will now be "very difficult" to add to the list of demands and concessions that have been agreed to, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said on Monday.

Speaking at the Munich Leaders Meeting here, she said India's imports of Russian oil did not feature as a condition during the negotiations for its free trade deal with the European Union.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 4

Trio wins medicine Nobel for 'controlling' neurons with light

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A trio of scientists was on Monday declared the winners of the 2026 Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine for discoveries leading to a technique called optogenetics, which allows scientists to control select nerve cells using light.

The Nobel Assembly said the work of the laureates – Karl Deisseroth, Peter Hegemann, and Georg Nagel – allowed neuroscience to move beyond observing correlations and testing how particular neurons and neural circuits are related to different behaviours and emotions.

Today, optogenetics helps scientists study schizophrenia, depression, Alzheimer's and Parkinson's diseases, and test treatments to restore vision and hearing loss.

In the 1990s, Mr. Hegemann, now at Humboldt University in Berlin, and his team found that shining light on a microscopic alga called *Chlamydomonas* rapidly triggered an electric signal within its body. He reasoned that the molecule involved in detecting light might be, or linked to, a protein that lets certain charged ions enter cells.

Optogenetics technique

The team of Mr. Deisseroth, who is at the Stanford University in U.S., published its first major result in 2005 using rat neurons, and a year later, the technique had its name: optogenetics.

In 2007, Mr. Deisseroth's group stimulated specific neurons in the brain of live mice with light sent through a slender fibre-optic cable, moving

Bright minds

The trio won the Nobel for contributions towards **optogenetics**, which helps in the study of schizophrenia, depression, and Alzheimer's disease



Peter Hegemann
Humboldt University of Berlin, Germany



Karl Deisseroth
Stanford University, U.S.



Georg Nagel
University of Würzburg, Germany

SC refuses to stay proceedings against Nicobar project

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

Saying that "preservation of culture is a constitutionally protected fundamental right", the Supreme Court on Monday refused to agree with a Union government plea to stay Calcutta High Court proceedings in a petition filed by former Union Environment Secretary Meena Gupta challenging the Great Nicobar Island Project as a threat to the area's fragile ecosystem and Forest Rights Act, 2006.

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant instead urged the Calcutta High Court to hear the case and decide the issues without delay.

Appearing for the Centre, Attorney-General R. Venkataramani and Ad-

ditional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati said the project worth over ₹72,000 crore involving a container terminal was of "immense" national importance and strategic value.

'No loss of habitat'

Mr. Venkataramani said there was "no loss of habitation" for the indigenous tribal population like the endangered Shompen tribe of the Great Nicobar Island.

Ms. Bhati submitted that the National Green Tribunal (NGT) had already twice disposed of the apprehensions raised regarding the project.

It had cleared the environmental clearance given to the project, subject to conditions and the formation of a High Powered Committee to re-examine



Preservation of culture is a constitutionally protected fundamental right... tribe culture requires constitutional protection

JUSTICE JOYMALYA BAGCHI
Supreme Court judge

specific ecological impacts. She said even a review against the environmental clearance was rejected by the NGT subsequently in April 2023.

Environmental threats

However, the Calcutta High Court had entertained writ petitions claiming that the project violated the Forest Rights Act, 2006, and highlighting severe environ-

mental threats it may allegedly cause.

Justice Joymalya Bagchi, on the Bench along with Justice V. Mohana, said there should be some degree of filtration between what constitutes the security of the state and what involved commercial interests.

"Preservation of culture is a constitutionally protected fundamental right. When you are talking about tribe cultures in Nicobar ecology... tribe culture requires constitutional protection," he observed orally.

In May, the High Court dismissed the Union government's preliminary objections regarding the *locus standi* of Ms. Gupta, banking on the submission that she was not a local. The High Court had scheduled the case for Novem-

ber 25 and November 26 for hearing constitutional issues centring on fundamental rights and preservation of the tribals' way of life.

Senior advocate S. Muralidhar, for Ms. Gupta, said the Centre's argument in maintainability of the writ petitions before the High Court has become academic as the tribal councils have already been impleaded.

Maintainability worry

Mr. Venkataramani said the tribes were integrated, and were not in the protected category.

"There is a lot of international..." he said.

"The Shompen are classified as a Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Group," Mr. Muralidhar intervened.

The Shompen and the Nicobarese tribes are said

to be affected by the project.

The Bench said the Union government could place the NGT decisions, with whatever persuasive value they may command, before the High Court.

Mr. Venkataramani urged the top court to at least allow the Centre to continue pressing the question of maintainability before the High Court.

But the Bench said it would limit itself to asking the High Court Chief Justice to decide the case, including all the petitions, without delay.

The petitions in the High Court had claimed that the diversion of over 130 sq. km of pristine tropical forest violated the Forest Rights Act, 2006, and threatened the Shompen and Nicobarese way of life and culture.

INBRIEF



Mayawati takes Akash back in BSP as national convener

Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) president Mayawati on Monday announced the reappointment of Akash Anand as the party’s national convener, saying the decision was taken in the interest of the party and the movement. “After considerable thought, the party has decided, in the interest of the party and the movement, to once again appoint Akash Anand as BSP’s national convener and give him an opportunity to work in the party again,” she wrote on X. On September 10, Ms. Mayawati had announced the ouster of Mr. Anand, her nephew, setting him “completely free” from all party responsibilities.

SC sets aside order by Bombay HC against Maharashtra FDA

The Supreme Court on Monday set aside a Bombay High Court direction ordering the Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) to pay ₹5 lakh in compensation to a Pune-based dairy and sweets establishment whose food licence was suspended following a food poisoning complaint. The order was passed in *State of Maharashtra & Ors. v. M/s Gurunanak Dairy & Sweets* on October 5, a press release issued by the FDA stated. The case dates to June 12, when FDA officers found deficiencies relating to labelling and personal hygiene of employees, following which its food licence was suspended under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006.

West Bengal BLOs write to CEO, seek security ahead of drive to re-enrol voters

Names of many voters were deleted in SIR ‘for no reason’: BLO body to CEO Meena; it adds while they had no role in ‘mass deletions’, BLOs may invite wrath of those whose names were removed

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA

An association of Booth Level Officers (BLOs) in West Bengal on Monday wrote to the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) seeking security arrangements during the survey to enrol new voters and re-enrol eligible voters whose names were deleted during the special intensive revision (SIR) drive ahead of the Assembly election in April.

On October 2, the Election Commission (EC) directed BLOs to visit houses across the country to enrol new voters and re-enrol eligible voters.

The association, Vote-karmi O BLO Aikya Mancha, said its members would have to work in “sensitive” areas during the survey where many voters’ names were deleted during the SIR, especially in eight districts – North 24 Parganas, South 24 Parganas, Howrah, Malda, Murshidabad, Uttar Dinajpur, and parts of Hooghly and



People whose names were removed from the roll standing outside a tribunal seeking re-inclusion of their names, in Nadia. FILE PHOTO

Kolkata. “In these districts, a huge number of voters were deleted for no reason. Though the BLOs had no role in this mass deletion, they may be the target of attacks by furious deleted voters. A system [logical discrepancy] raised the question of the credentials of these deleted voters,” read the letter they sent to CEO Neelam Meena. The BLOs said that then Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee’s role in drawing them to court played a

pivotal role in forcing them to come under adjudication and ultimately to the tribunal.

It added, “The BLOs may be victims of the wrath of those deleted voters at the time of special drive. We are apprehensive of this situation.”

They requested that appropriate measures be undertaken to ensure the security of the BLOs working in the sensitive areas.

The names of over 91 lakh voters were deleted in

West Bengal in the SIR drive. Of these, around 27 lakh later appealed before tribunals seeking the restoration of their names.

Meanwhile, the EC on Monday replaced the Inspector-in-charge of the Nandigram police station, a day before the bypoll to the Nandigram Assembly seat, a senior officer said. Debashis Sarkar was appointed to the post, replacing Ajay Kumar Mishra. The development comes after Opposition parties approached the commission, alleging that Mr. Mishra was close to the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party.

The State police force underwent a major reshuffle ahead of the poll. Several officers were transferred across districts as part of efforts to ensure a “transparent election process”.

Nandigram played a big role in Trinamool Congress chief Mamata Banerjee’s rise during the 2007-08 anti-land-grab agitation. In 2021, she was defeated by Suwendu Adhikari.

(With inputs from PTI)

19,000 Bengal voters to miss bypolls over backlog in tribunals

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

Nearly 19,000 voters in West Bengal’s Nandigram and Rejinagar Assembly constituencies, where byelections will be held on Tuesday, are among the 38.31 lakh voters who remain disenfranchised due to the crawling pace of work at the Appellate Tribunals that handle their pending cases.

The Calcutta High Court had in July observed that at the current rate, it would take 21 years for the tribunals to clear the cases.

In Rejinagar, the total number of appeals submitted was 12,452, out of which four have been included so far, and in Nandigram, the total number of appeals submitted was 6,443, with 89 included so far. While in both places, no one has been excluded so far, the tribunals have till now cleared only 1.26 lakh of the total 38.31 lakh appeals – approximately 3% of the total cases.

Out of the 19 Appellate Tribunals set up by the Election Commission (EC) in March, only 16 remain functional as three retired judges – Justice T.S. Sivagnanam, Justice Ranjit Bag and Justice Indrajit Chatterjee – have quit citing va-

The EC’s proposal to increase the number of tribunals from 19 to 42 has also not moved forward

rious functional issues. Their positions remain vacant.

The EC’s proposal to increase the number of tribunals from 19 to 42 has also not moved forward. The Supreme Court was scheduled to hear the matter on Monday, but it was not listed.

The poll body’s special “door-to-door” drive to re-enrol any voter left behind during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process through Form 6, announced last week, will also not be applicable to them.

The Appellate Tribunals came out of the Supreme Court’s supervision of the SIR. Judicial officers, drawn from a list the Calcutta High Court sent at the Supreme Court’s direction, were adjudicating the roughly 60 lakh “doubtful and pending” cases. On March 10, the top court directed that a separate appellate body be set up so that people could challenge those officers’ decisions.

U.P. poll: tussle with SP not just over numbers but winnability of seats too, say Cong. leaders

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Amid a war of words over seat sharing for the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly election, Congress leaders on Monday said the tussle with the Samajwadi Party (SP) is not just about the number of seats but also their quality. Alleging that it is “well known that the SP tries to give difficult seats” to the Congress, they said the national party wants to secure winnable seats this time.

The two parties are partners in the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance bloc.

“Quality seats matter in any alliance. Here also [in the SP-Congress alliance], quality along with quantity will matter,” Imran Masood, working president of



Quality and quantity of seats will matter, Congress leader Imran Masood said. FILE PHOTO

the State Congress unit, told *The Hindu*.

Another senior party leader said any workable framework on seat sharing must be in accordance with ground realities.

He recalled that in the 2017 poll, the Congress was given 105 seats in the alliance and won only seven. “The alliance partner will question the strike rate. But they are downplaying

the fact that out of the 100-odd seats, more than 70 were extremely difficult,” the leader said, adding that many of these were urban seats or mostly represented by the BJP in the past.

The leader said a realistic approach should be taken to divide difficult seats equally and the remaining seats in the ratio of 2:1 between the SP and the Congress. He said no one can deny the appeal of Congress leader Rahul Gandhi among downtrodden social groups. This, he said, was evident from the 2024 Lok Sabha poll outcome.

The Congress said 80-odd seats in Uttar Pradesh are “difficult” for the alliance to win in light of past outcomes and social realities, while the rest are “normal”. The State has a 403-member Assembly.

MLC poll: Anant Singh refuses to back party nominee; 3 RLM MLAs float own candidate

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Turmoil within the constituent National Democratic Alliance (NDA) parties appears to be growing ahead of the Bihar Legislative Council election. Senior Janata Dal (United) leader and Union Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh alias Lalan Singh who was tasked with ending differences between party legislators Anant Singh and Neeraj Kumar, on Monday admitted that he could not persuade Mr. Anant to back Mr. Neeraj, the sitting MLC from the Patna Graduates’ seat who has been renominated by the party.

Meanwhile, coalition partner Rashtriya Lok Morcha (RLM) also faced dissent, with three of its four MLAs announcing their own candidate, Ram Pukar Sinha, in the biennial poll instead of the official can-



Mokama MLA Anant Singh of JD(U) has openly supported a JSP candidate. FILE PHOTO

didate – JD(U)’s Anand Pushkar. The last date for filing nominations for the eight seats is October 6. Polling will be held on October 23 and votes will be counted on October 27.

‘Misinformation’

Speaking to mediapersons in Patna, Mr. Lalan Singh said, “Today I spoke to Anant Singh. He expressed some reservations, as when he was contesting

the Assembly election from Mokama, as directed by party chief Nitish Kumar, misinformation was spread against him. However, the party did not act against the person despite an appeal by Anant Singh.”

The gangster-turned-politician, who went on to win the seat, has accused Mr. Neeraj of spreading canards against him during the 2025 State poll.

“He [Mr. Anant] said he wouldn’t support Neeraj. I requested him not to make any statement against the party or the candidate and he agreed,” Mr. Lalan said.

Earlier in the day, JD(U) chief and former Chief Minister Nitish Kumar and Mr. Lalan Singh held a meeting at the latter’s residence in the State capital, reportedly related to Mr. Anant’s “rebellion”.

The Mokama MLA has made no secret of his in-

tent to ensure Mr. Neeraj’s defeat in the October 23 poll. Mr. Anant not only announced his support for the Jan Suraj Party (JSP) candidate, Anuj Kumar, but also took out a procession in support of the Opposition party candidate.

Mr. Neeraj filed his nomination papers on Monday. Addressing reporters later, he said he did not care who was opposing him. “The party has only one centre – Nitish Kumar – and I’ve got his blessings,” said Mr. Neeraj.

The three RLM legislators who announced their decision to go against party president Upendra Kushwaha’s direction to support the JD(U) candidate in the Saran Teachers’ constituency said they were doing so “out of respect and self-esteem” of party workers. Mr. Kushwaha’s wife, Snehlata, is the fourth RLM legislator.

DMK gets nod to file ₹1-crore suit against TVK Ministers

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Monday granted leave (permission) to the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) to file a ₹1-crore defamation suit against Ministers Aadhav Arjuna and C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar and the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) Information Technology wing.

The plaintiff, represented by party general secretary Duraimurugan, had filed the suit seeking damages for reportedly accusing the DMK, which was then in power, of having “shielded” child sexual abuse case accused R. Vee-ramani. The plea contended that an FIR had been registered just a day after an activist handed over a video clipping of the alleged sexual assault to the police.

Historic international shipment leaves eastern Assam

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

A barge carrying 540 metric tonnes of methanol left the Bogibeel Terminal in Dibrugarh district for Dhaka, Bangladesh, on Monday, marking the first international shipment from eastern Assam since India’s independence in 1947.

Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, Sarbananda Sonowal, flagged off the vessel *DLB Patkai*, pushed by the tug *Kushal Konwar*, carrying methanol produced by the State-owned Assam Petrochemicals Limited in Namrup.

The vessel, destined for Pangaon port in Dhaka’s Narayanganj, will travel about 768 km down the Brahmaputra river (National Waterway-2) to the India-Bangladesh border, and continue along the Indo-Bangladesh Protocol



Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways Sarbananda Sonowal flagging off the first international cargo vessel from Bogibeel in Dibrugarh district. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Route in the neighbouring country. The total distance is about 1,300 km.

Mr. Sonowal said the cargo shipment is seen as a test of whether the Brahmaputra can serve as a commercially viable freight corridor linking the northeastern region to overseas markets.

“Our grandparents grew up hearing the steamer whistle at Dibrugarh ghat. For 70 years, that whistle

fell silent, and the ships stopped coming. A cargo vessel has left Dibrugarh for the world once again. The river never failed us, but the will to revive the route was lacking for decades,” he said.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, who attended the flagging-off virtually, said the revival of international cargo movement was a “proud day for Assam”.

Inland Waterways Authority of India officials said the shipment became possible after Customs and Immigration complexes were recently set up at Bogibeel and Dhubri.

Busy past

Dibrugarh was once among the busiest river ports in eastern India. Government-run steamers reached the town from Calcutta, now Kolkata, by 1856. In 1882, the Dibrugarh Railway began operating from the Dibrugarh ghat. By 1913, steamers sailed up the Brahmaputra to the town daily, carrying tea, timber and passengers.

The 1947 Partition cut that route, forcing Assam’s goods to pass through the then East Pakistan to reach Calcutta. A 1950 earthquake disturbed the riverbed at Dibrugarh, and regular bookings from Di-

brugarh ghat stopped in 1954. The Dibrugarh ghat closed on October 15, 1956, as western ports on the Brahmaputra – Dhubri and Pandu in Guwahati – continued to handle international cargo occasionally.

The 1965 war between India and Pakistan suspended cross-border river trade. India and Bangladesh signed a river trade protocol in 1972. In 1988, the 891 km stretch of the Brahmaputra from Sadiya to Dhubri was declared National Waterway 2. Regular cargo service on the waterway resumed in December 2017, when cement moved from Pandu to Dhubri.

“Every tonne we move on the river means less fuel burnt and fewer trucks on the highway,” he said, adding that India is working with Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, and Myanmar on regional waterway links.

Aaditya Thackeray to join protest against MPSC in Pune; Rahul may meet protesters this week

Yohan Varghese
MUMBAI

Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Aaditya Thackeray will join protesting Maharashtra Public Service Commission (MPSC) aspirants in Pune on Tuesday, stepping up the Opposition’s support for students demanding the removal of the commission’s chairperson, Vivek Bhimanwar, and changes in the recruitment body’s functioning.

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi is also likely to meet the protesters in Pune this week.

The MPSC has postponed the State Services Main Examination, which was scheduled to be held on October 3. The protests have drawn support from

several Opposition leaders.

NCP(SP) MLA Rohit Pawar on Monday said the agitation would intensify if the government does not address the students’ concerns within 48 hours. He added, “We have learnt that Rahul Gandhi is likely to come by Wednesday or Thursday. Leaders from Congress’s youth wing are also agitating, and they are in contact with his team.”

‘Spoke to aspirant’

Referring to an aspirant from a farming family in Kolhapur who has become one of the most prominent faces of the stir, Mr. Thackeray wrote on X: “I have just spoken to Vivekanand Patil. Tomorrow, I will go and sit with the students participating in the MPSC

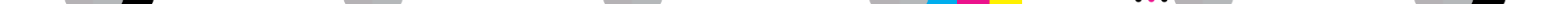
agitation in Pune.”

He also questioned Mr. Bhimanwar’s continuation in office despite “lakhs of students rejecting you and asking you to step aside”.

The agitation in Pune has continued for several days, with aspirants raising a range of demands concerning the functioning of the commission. These include greater transparency in examinations and the removal of its chairperson. Protesters have been gathering at multiple locations in the city.

On September 30, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis met a delegation of MPSC aspirants and announced a series of measures, including the transfer of the MPSC secretary.

(With inputs from PTI)

CM YK  A IN-X

Delhi Police file FIR against those seeking action against ACP

Gyanesh Kumar changed Form 6 ‘illegally’ during SIR, says Rahul

Congress accuses the CEC of ‘betraying’ the Constitution, seeks his resignation and scrapping of SIR; reacting to Supreme Court’s observation, Jairam says it has opportunity to restore public confidence in EC; poll body fact-checks Rahul’s X post

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Mounting an offensive against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, the Congress on Monday accused him of “lying” after the Supreme Court said it had not approved any of the changes made to Form 6 during the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

Form 6 is an application through which an eligible person seeks inclusion in the electoral roll for the first time.

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, on his X handle, shared a screenshot of the September 26 Election Commission (EC) statement which read – “The declaration attached to Form 6 for SIR has been upheld by the Hon’ble Su-



It is now established beyond doubt that Gyanesh Kumar changed Form 6 illegally and unilaterally. This is just one more proof of him abusing his position to help the BJP. He...will be held accountable

RAHUL GANDHI
Congress leader

preme Court. For non-SIR period, the Forms applicable as per Rules (the Registration of Electors Rules 1960) will be used.”

“It is now established beyond doubt that Mr. Kumar changed Form 6 illegally and unilaterally. This is just one more proof of him abusing his position to help the BJP. He and everyone else involved in this criminal assault on our democracy will be held accountable,” he said.

However, the Election Commission fact-checked

Mr. Gandhi in a post on X. It said Mr. Gandhi’s post was misleading, asserting that the June 24, 2025 order for the SIR in Bihar was issued with the unanimous approval of the EC and was upheld by the Supreme Court in its May 27 judgment. Further, the September 26 press note, categorically stated that the declaration attached to Form 6 for the SIR had been upheld by the Supreme Court.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said resig-

nation of the CEC, annulling the SIR and conducting elections on ballot papers are “non-negotiable demands” of the principal Opposition party.

‘In solidarity’

Mr. Kharge said Congress workers and INDIA bloc partners are on the streets over these three issues across the country. He said the Congress stands in solidarity with civil society members and youth organisations that are struggling on these issues in various places across the country.

“The dictator is extremely panicked; get ready for another chapter in the distraction tactics,” Mr. Kharge said.

Taking note of the Supreme Court’s notices to the EC and the Centre and the top court’s observation, Congress communications chief Jairam Ra-

mesh said the Supreme Court has a remarkable opportunity to restore public confidence in the EC.

He accused the CEC of “betraying” the Constitution in letter and spirit at the behest of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

“Based on the recent damning revelations regarding (1) the ad-hoc, illegal and slipshod manner in which the SIR was taking place, (2) criticism from both sitting and retired Judges of the Supreme Court, (3) the vast and indiscriminate (and many obviously incorrect) deletions without adequate due process, the Supreme Court has a remarkable opportunity to restore public confidence in an institution vital to the integrity of our republic,” the Congress leader said on X.

CEC has lost public trust, must be removed: activists

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

A group of retired bureaucrats, civil society activists, and academics on Monday accused Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar of six instances of “proved misbehaviour” and sought his removal.

They could not submit their “notice of impeachment” to him in person, as heavy barricading and police deployment prevented the delegation from reaching the Election Commission’s office.

They subsequently emailed their “chargesheet” to the CEC. It invokes Article 324(5) of the Constitution, which protects the CEC from removal except on grounds of “proved misbehaviour or incapacity”, and alleges that the CEC’s conduct amounted to a sustained disregard of law and constitutional duty.

The 14-member delegation included former Delhi Lieutenant-Governor Najeeb Jung, former Union



Taking a stand: Activist Anjali Bhardwaj and former Delhi Lieutenant-Governor Najeeb Jung in New Delhi on Monday. ANI

Home Secretary G.K. Pillai, and other former IAS officers and Ambassadors.

Six accusations

The chargesheet lists six accusations against Mr. Kumar, including that he undermined the collective functioning of the EC, made unauthorised changes to the statutory Form 6, centralised electoral-roll functions through the ECINET platform, and presided over the special intensive revision of electoral rolls that the activists alleged has resulted in large-scale disenfranchisement.

The group said the charges amounted to a “people’s impeachment” of the CEC and argued that he had lost the public trust necessary to continue in office. “EC is functioning illegally and failing in its responsibility. We believe that the CEC must resign,” activist Anjali Bhardwaj said.

The chargesheet alleges that the conduct of the EC had compromised citizens’ ability to establish their eligibility for inclusion in the electoral rolls, adding that such conduct undermined the EC’s public credibility.

After SC notice, BJP hits out at Rahul for ‘spreading lies and confusion’ over Form 6

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI

Rejecting Congress leader Rahul Gandhi’s charge regarding Form 6 used for registering new voters, the BJP on Monday said the Supreme Court’s decision to issue notices to the Centre and the Election Commission demonstrated a functioning democratic process.

BJP spokesperson Sambit Patra accused Mr. Gandhi of “spreading lies and confusion regarding Form 6”, arguing that the Supreme Court had neither called it illegal nor rejected it.

Responding to Mr. Gandhi’s charge in an X post that Form 6 was changed illegally and unilaterally to help the BJP, Mr. Patra said: “Nowhere in court today did the Chief Justice say that Form 6 was illegal.”

He said the Supreme Court had earlier upheld the declaration attached to Form 6 for the special intensive revision (SIR) of



This is exactly like the way Rahul Gandhi had said regarding Rafale... Later, he had to file an affidavit before the Supreme Court and apologise

SAMBIT PATRA
BJP spokesperson

electoral rolls. “Rahul Gandhi is saying that Form 6 was illegal and that today the Supreme Court is also saying the same thing. This is exactly like the way Rahul Gandhi had said regarding Rafale that the Supreme Court had pointed to a ‘major scam’ in Rafale. Later, Rahul Gandhi had to file an affidavit before the Supreme Court and apologise,” said Mr. Patra, accusing the Congress leader of trying to create anarchy by spreading “false statements”.

During a press conference earlier in the day, Mr. Patra said: “Going to the Supreme Court with a PIL, having the Supreme Court hear it, and issuing notice

so that the other side can also be heard, is a democratic and judicial process. Therefore, naturally, a process is taking place.”

Referring to the controversy surrounding Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and the reported dissent notes written by the two other Election Commissioners, Mr. Patra said communication between the two Election Commissioners and the CEC was a “healthy sign of democracy”.

“There is no atmosphere of fear in the country. There is an atmosphere of democracy in the country... all institutions in the country are functioning independently,” he said.

Cong. to launch campaign against vote chori, help re-enrol deleted names

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Monday announced a series of nationwide campaigns against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and alleged vote theft, using a slogan of ‘Vote bachao, desh bachao’ (Save your vote, save the country).

Congress workers will reach out to more than 13.3 crore people whose names have been struck off the voters’ list during the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, and will try to get them re-enrolled with the help of “vote rakshaks [guardians]”.

The announcement was made after Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge chaired a two-hour long meeting of party general secretaries, State in-charges, and Pradesh Congress Committee chiefs at the Indira Bhavan here. The Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, was also present at the meeting.

“The Election Commission has become the Cheating Commission of India,”



Plan of action: Congress leaders K.C. Venugopal, Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi at a meeting in New Delhi on Monday. ANI

Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal said. “[Gyanesh Kumar] is not leaving, even as the entire country wants him to be removed. We are not going to allow him to sit on the chair. We will ensure that he is removed,” he added.

The Opposition party will also reach out to other parties outside the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) bloc, like the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam and the Aam Aadmi Party, and invite them to join the planned protest march from Parliament to the Election Commission on

Tuesday and a INDIA bloc rally here on November 1.

“We are inviting all the Opposition parties to be part of the November 1 rally at the Ram Leela Maidan,” general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said.

‘BJP’s distractions’

Sources told *The Hindu* that, in the closed door meeting, Mr. Kharge said the Opposition party should “oust the CEC now”, but also cautioned that the ruling party may use distractions as “they [the BJP] know they have been caught out”.

Mr. Gandhi said the al-

leged “vote chori [theft]” is a people’s issue and the party’s campaign should be designed in such a way that common people should the programmes to protect their voting rights.

Giving details of the various programmes, Mr. Venugopal said from October 10 to October 20, block level marches will be taken out and culminate at Sub Divisional Magistrates offices under Vote bachao, desh bachao umbrella.

“Village chaupals will be held in every village, where our workers will explain Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah’s modus operandi of vote chori, and village leaders and heads will be invited. Booth-level agents (BLAs), our vote rakshaks, will have the task of identifying every voter deleted unfairly and ensuring their re-enrolment,” Mr. Venugopal said.

The Congress will then take out six Delhi Chalo rallies from locations in Rajasthan, Haryana, and Uttar Pradesh on November 25, culminating in an event in Delhi on Constitution Day, November 26.

D. Raja slams Gyanesh over ‘changes to Form 6’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Calling for Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar’s resignation for allegedly misleading the public over changes made to Form 6, Communist Party of India (CPI) general secretary D. Raja said the Supreme Court’s remarks on the issue on Monday raised questions over the Election Commission’s credibility and impartiality.

Mr. Raja alleged that Mr. Kumar had invoked the Supreme Court’s name to justify the changes and had ignored objections raised by the other Election Commissioners. “This is utterly shameless,” Mr. Raja said in a post on social media platform X.

The Election Commission, Mr. Raja said, needs to provide answers on who changed Form 6, and who authorised the false claim with reference to the Supreme Court.

“It is imperative that this man must resign if electoral democracy is to survive,” Mr. Raja said.

Cong. flags FII outflows, says BJP ‘wrecked’ the economy

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Monday blamed the economic policies of the Narendra Modi government for foreign institutional investors (FIIs) pulling out of the Indian markets.

Addressing a press conference, Congress leader Shaktisinh Gohil claimed that FIIs had withdrawn ₹4.03 lakh crore from Indian markets between January and September, and accused the BJP-led government of “wrecking” the economy. “With foreign investors offloading around ₹29,000 crore in the three trading sessions of September 29, 30 and October 1, this is a major concern,” Mr. Gohil said.

He demanded that the government explain the sustained FII outflows, and the rupee’s depreciation.

HC orders CBI probe into corruption charges linked to Punjab CM’s office

Vikas Vasudeva
CHANDIGARH

The Punjab and Haryana High Court on Monday directed the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) to probe corruption allegations linked to Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann’s office.

The allegations raised by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) against public servants and private individuals linked to the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) government include corruption in transfers and postings, policy manipulation, cash for tenders, and other such serious irregularities.

Pronouncing its order on a public interest litigation case, the Bench of Chief Justice Ashwani Kumar Mishra and Justice Rohit Kapoor said a fair and transparent investigation was required into the issue. Expressing its dissatis-



If [AAP] govt. is truly so honest, why did the HC find it necessary to bring in an independent agency to investigate matter

PARTAP SINGH BAJWA,
Leader of the Opposition in the Punjab Assembly

faction with the manner in which the Punjab Police had handled the matter so far, the court said in its order: “We are also not impressed by the manner in which Punjab Police has acted so far in the matter, and therefore we deem it appropriate to entrust investigation of the present case to the Central Bureau of Investigation, which will register an First Information Report (FIR) and proceed with the investigation forthwith.” A report with regard to outcome of the investigation shall be sub-

mitted to the court within two months, the Bench directed.

The petition relates to allegations surrounding the involvement of senior officers of Punjab in various scams, including cash for transfers, cash in return for favourable policies, cash for tenders with regard to which no investigation had been held, despite the sharing of information with the Punjab Police by the ED.

Opposition parties, meanwhile, hit out the AAP government. The

Leader of the Opposition in the Punjab Assembly, Congress’s Partap Singh Bajwa, demanded the immediate resignation of Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, saying the High Court’s decision had raised serious questions on the functioning of the State government, and the Chief Minister’s own responsibility.

“The Punjab government proudly advertises Bhagwant Mann as an imandaaar (honest) Chief Minister. But if the government is truly so honest, why did the High Court find it necessary to bring in an independent agency to investigate the matter?” said Mr. Bajwa.

In New Delhi, Bharatiya Janata Party leader Sambit Patra asked AAP supremo and national convenor Arvind Kejriwal and Mr. Mann to clarify on the allegations.

Tejashwi alleges electoral fraud, claims CEC-BJP nexus

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

The leaders of the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) in Bihar will launch an Aakrosh March on Wednesday against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, and Union Home Minister Amit Shah over the alleged illegalities in the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

Sharing the details of the Opposition movement on Monday, Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) national working president Tejashwi Yadav said the INDIA bloc planned a nationwide movement during its Delhi meeting to protest the alleged conspiracy by Mr. Modi, Mr. Shah, and the CEC to dismantle democracy.

He was accompanied by Kapil Dev Prasad Yadav



Tejashwi Yadav

from Congress, Mukesh Sahani of Vikassheel Insaan Party, Ramnaresh Pandey of Communist Party of India (CPI), Dharendra Jha of CPI (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation, Ajay Kumar and I.P. Gupta of Indian Inclusive Party.

The Aakrosh march will be followed by a sit-in protest in all districts on Thursday and a demonstration at the Lok Bhavan in Patna – led Mr. Yadav, who is the Leader of the Opposition in the Bihar Assembly.

Mr. Yadav also alleged on Monday that the CEC has become a puppet of

the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), citing irregularities, such as the mass removal of voters’ names from electoral rolls and wrongly marking them as dead.

‘Votes purchased’

He also pointed out that ₹10,000 was deposited into women’s accounts right up to the election day, in violation of the Model Code of Conduct, to benefit the National Democratic Alliance in the Bihar Assembly election. The RJD leader claimed that ₹50,000 crore was siphoned from the State treasury to purchase votes.

“Voting records were previously retained for a year but Gyanesh Kumar changed the rule to reduce this period to 45 days; this clearly reveals his intentions. There was electoral fraud in Bihar. The Commission is acting in the interest of the BJP,” Mr. Yadav alleged.

INBRIEF



Centre elevates three HC Chief Justices to top court

The Centre on Monday appointed the Chief Justices of the Gujarat, Delhi, and Telangana High Courts to the Supreme Court. The three additional judges will take the court's working strength to 37, leaving one vacancy against its sanctioned strength of 38. Union Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal said on X that Justice Sunita Agarwal, Chief Justice of the Gujarat High Court; Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya, Chief Justice of the Delhi High Court; and Justice Aparesh Kumar Singh, Chief Justice of the Telangana High Court have been appointed to the Supreme Court. They are set to be sworn in on October 6.

Indian-born cheetah gives birth to five cubs in MP's Kuno

An Indian-born cheetah has given birth to five cubs in Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh's Sheopur district, taking the total number of the big cats in the country to 60, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav said in a statement on Monday. The birth of these cubs marks the beginning of the Botswana lineage in India, adding a new genetic lineage to the country's growing cheetah population. Their birth marks a glorious chapter in remarkable journey of Project Cheetah and has sparked an outpouring of joy, Mr. Yadav said.

SC seeks govt. response on Delhi library relocation

Aaratrika Bhaumik
DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday sought a detailed affidavit from the Union government on the proposed relocation of the 135-year-old Central Secretariat Library in Delhi, which houses over 8.5 lakh books, as part of the Central Vista redevelopment project. The court sought details of the space earmarked for the library, along with its layout plans. A Bench of Justices Sanjay Kumar and Sanjeev Sachdeva directed Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati, appearing for the Union government, to file an affidavit within three weeks setting out the arrangements made for the library. The court's *suo motu* intervention comes amid reports that the library was directed on September 17 to vacate the premises by September 30 as part of the redevelopment project.

Bharat Innovation Challenge returns for its second edition

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Bharat Innovation Challenge is back with its second edition. Organised and hosted by Lovely Professional University (LPU), the Bharat Innovation Challenge 2.0 urges students from Classes 8-12 aged between 13 and 18 years to participate and identify real-world problems and develop innovative, practical, and scalable solutions. Season 2 has 10 innovation themes, 29 winning categories, ₹14 lakh in cash prizes, including a ₹3 lakh Grand Champion prize, along with theme-wise and special awards. The top teams will advance to the grand finale at LPU, to be held on November 20-21. Registrations and online submissions close on October 10. Students can participate in teams of two-five, with one faculty mentor and develop solutions across 10 themes: Agritech & Rural Innovation, Healthcare &



HealthTech, Smart Living & Urban Intelligence, Cybersecurity & Ethical Tech, Education & EdTech, Climate & Sustainable Tech, Aerospace & Frontier Tech, AI & GenAI, FinTech & Financial Inclusion, and Social Impact, Culture & Heritage. "India's young minds have potential to turn today's biggest challenges into tomorrow's solutions. Through Bharat Innovation Challenge, we want to give school students a national platform where their ideas are encouraged, mentored and transformed into solutions with real impact," Ashok Kumar

Mittal, founder-chancellor, LPU and MP (Rajya Sabha), said. The competition will take place in two stages. Stage 1 involves online registration and submission of ideas through a power-point presentation or PDF. Entries will be evaluated on innovation, problem-solving, feasibility, impact, scalability and presentation. The top teams will advance to the grand finale, where students will showcase their innovations and pitch it before experts and industry leaders. The initiative is supported by *The Hindu in School* as media partner, Quantiphi as AI Partner, Kangaro as stationery partner and Scarters as lifestyle partner. For registrations, the participants can email: bic@lpu.co.in and dial +919888598702 for further details. The registration link is <https://www.lpu.in/bharat-innovation-challenge/> or scan the QR code.



THE HINDU CROSSWORD+ 14916

(set by Karaoke)

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Across

1 Mrs. Henry rues uncontrollably while narrating unknown verses for children (7,6)

10 Where a train should be to make progress? (2,5)

11 Perfect to enjoy long time in retreat (7)

12 Lack of interest, of course, in any case (6)

13 Spooner's father gambles amounts that can never be recovered (3,5)

Down

2 Diehard setter opts out of ritual dance (5)

3 Something to eat during breaks over the table mainly perhaps with Karaoke (9)

4 Ignore boy, check for playboy (4)

5 Fact-finding coordinator at centre leaves his career in a fit of anger (8)

6 Why I say, silently leave trophy and admit defeat (5)

7 Found enjoyment, going topless, holding rounded clubs (9)

8 Some rural man confused about new CIVIL ID perhaps? (5,8)

9 Terrible loss for other Congress mainly when politicians join the opposite side (5,3,5)

15 Mock up one person without natural covering mostly in loose blouse (9)

17 Inspector shot main criminal for major offence within boundaries (9)

18 Mercenary from Edinburgh working to eliminate bishop (5,3)

22 Part of hospital is tailor-made for noted celebrities in the show business (1-4)

24 Heavy-weight wife leaves Newton, while cycling (5)

25 Two-toed sloth runs heartily on the banks of Anapu (4)

‘We need to foster a middle power approach’

India, a respected actor on the international stage, can help in finding a peaceful solution to the Ukraine war, says the French Minister-Delegate for European Affairs; stressing that India and France share a common attachment to multilateralism, he says the EU seeks de-escalation in West Asia crisis

I don't think it's 'versus'. I think we are attached to a world that's driven by reliable partnerships, by cooperation and multilateralism in international law. We have our traditional allies, and we are very committed to the European project, but we can see that with partners like India, we share the objective of not just being passive bystanders of a rivalry between the United States and China, but also to be able to defend our own interest. In areas like access to space and leadership of AI, I think there is really an incredible potential for a partnership. The India-EU FTA will only operationalise and deepen this. And

one of the reasons for my visits, my second visit this year, is beyond just the signature of [the FTA] document; [it] is to look at how we can take it to a stronger partnership and a common voice on the international stage.

An area of disagreement is the Russia-Ukraine conflict. What is your expectation from India, given it still imports more than half its oil needs from Russia?

I've seen Indian leaders state very clearly that they want to find a peaceful solution, including Prime Minister Modi, who told President Putin that it's time to

stop the wars. In this respect, a country like India, that is a respected actor on the international stage, can play a role in working with us to find a peaceful solution , but clearly Russia continues to refuse. The best way to put an end to this war is to increase the pressure on Russia to get it back to the negotiating table, and so it means also increasing economic pressures. We generally don't lecture other countries on what they should do, but at the European level, we have adopted different packages of sanctions.

The recent BRICS Summit ‘Delhi Declaration’ made no mention of the Ukraine war. Does this indicate that it is now just a European problem, not for the rest of the world?

It would be [a] mistake to think that. Of course it is a European issue, as it pertains to European security. [But] this is also about international principles, not just law, [but] of the security architecture that we want. If we allow a state to

invade its neighbour, to use nuclear blackmail to conduct a conventional war on its neighbours, it creates an extremely dangerous precedent for the rest of the world, including for the nations that were at this BRICS Summit.

The U.S. invasion of Iran earlier this year, the assassination of its Supreme Leader, of civilians there, targeting of nuclear installations, also ticks all these boxes, and yet no one is asking for the U.S. to be treated the same way...

Europeans are not involved in [the Iran] war. We have always called for de-escalation. We have always called to find peaceful and diplomatic solutions, whether that's on the freedom of navigation, the Strait of Hormuz, including on tackling issues where we agree with the U.S. for example, the Iranian nuclear programme, its ballistic missile programme, its support for terrorist proxies in the region. We said the best way is to do it through a diplomatic channel.

‘Hasina’s activities pose challenge to planning Bangladesh PM’s India trip’

Kallol Bhattacharjee
DHAKA

The activities of deposed premier Sheikh Hasina and her team pose the “principal challenge” to planning a visit to India by Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman, State Minister for Foreign Affairs of Bangladesh Humaiyun Kobir said on Monday.

Responding to questions from *The Hindu* on the sidelines of the ongoing Bay of Bengal Conversation organised by Dhaka's Centre for Governance Studies (CGS), Mr. Kobir emphasised the importance of “strategic autonomy” for Bangladesh and said India has to appreciate the “challenges of a newly elected government” in Bangladesh.

“The visit will be bilateral but there are challenges and through dialogue we will overcome them. The principal challenge is not too much to ask for. Sheikh Hasina and her team are stationed in Delhi and they

Humaiyun Kobir

are trying to destabilise a foreign country sitting in Delhi. This does not benefit India either,” Mr. Kobir said, calling on India to restrain Ms. Hasina.

Mr. Kobir accused Ms. Hasina of killing around 2,000 Bangladeshi citizens during the crackdown of the uprising of July-August 2024 and described her as a “terrorist”.

He said Bangladesh's people need a “clean break” from the past as they have sacrificed lives in the process of overthrowing the previous government of Ms. Hasina that ruled for more than 15 years.

The Minister, however, said there are ongoing talks with India that have been welcomed in Dhaka.

“We are seeing some positive signs as India is trying to restrain them (Ms. Hasina and her group). That is the norm between two countries. If they are restrained, then there will be no problem in the [bilateral] relationship,” said Mr. Kobir asserting that ties with India are a priority for Dhaka. “The visit of Prime Minister will take place at a conducive time and I am hopeful. PM has never said that he will not visit [India],” said Mr. Kobir highlighting the role of Indian High Commissioner Dinesh Trivedi in this regard.

Indian envoy’s role “The Indian High Commissioner here is doing a good role. He is trying and hopefully Delhi will be receptive to his opinion and if they give importance to his opinion, then we are ready to engage across the board.

We are carrying out our consultations,” said Mr. Kobir describing the Awami League leadership as a “hindrance” to normalisation of New Delhi-Dhaka ties.

The State Minister of Foreign Affairs said that Bangladesh is ready to discuss all issues but expects some “reciprocation”. “When two governments sit down to discuss keeping in mind national interests, all issues can be addressed,” he said arguing that Bangladesh will not allow anyone to work against India's interest sitting in Dhaka and he expects similar action from India.

Earlier, Mr. Kobir delivered a “ministerial address” at the Bay of Bengal Conversation and said Bangladesh seeks “strategic autonomy” in foreign affairs but will maintain strong relation with global stakeholders.

(The correspondent is visiting Dhaka as a guest of the Centre for Governance Studies)

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH

Selfless service

Lord Siva's penance has to be disrupted if He is to marry Parvati. And only if they marry, will Murugan take His avatara. So, Brahma asks Manmatha to disrupt Siva's tapas. Afraid of Siva's anger, Manmatha refuses, and Brahma uses his persuasive skills to convince Manmatha. He tells Manmatha that one must be selfless and must help those who need assistance, said Sumathi Sri in a discourse. He tells him the story of Dadhichi. When the war between the devas and the asuras came to an end, the devas left their weapons in Dadhichi's ashram, telling him that they would collect the weapons whenever a war broke out again. Many years passed, and since the devas did not come to take their weapons, Dadhichi dissolved the weapons in the sacred water in his kamandala, and drank it. As a result, his backbone became a strong weapon. When Indra had to fight Vritasura, he went to retrieve the weapons. The sage told Indra that he had consumed the weapons, but Indra could use the sage's backbone to fashion a weapon. This meant that Dadhichi had to die. But he didn't mind dying for a good cause. He told Indra to take his backbone. The weapon known as Vajrayudha was made out of Dadhichi's bone. Brahma asks Manmatha to think of the ultimate sacrifice of Dadhichi. Shouldn't Manmatha think of others, instead of thinking only about himself? Brahma tells Manmatha about the churning of the milky ocean, and of Lord Siva's selflessness. When the Halahala poison emerged from the ocean, it posed a danger to everyone. To save everyone, Siva tried to swallow it, but Parvati clutched His throat, and the poison remained in His neck. That is why Siva is known as Neelakanta.

New discovery comes ‘close’ to test biology’s central dogma

The discovery of a protein that can, by itself, dictate the sequence of nucleic acids has caused a stir in the scientific community; commentaries accompanying the work have highlighted the unusual nature of the finding and its implications for one of the foundational ideas of molecular biology

Arun Panchapakesan

The field of molecular biology began when scientists attempted to answer a simple question: what molecule makes up the genetic material of an organism? In the early 1900s, when the field was still in its infancy, there were two plausible candidates: nucleic acids (DNA and RNA) and proteins. At the time, proteins were the preferred candidates thanks to their diverse building blocks. All proteins (on the earth) are made up of some combination of 20 amino acids. Nucleic acids on the other hand were made up of just four nucleotides, leading to fewer molecular combinations than scientists believed were necessary for the carriers of heredity. In 1944, three scientists – Oswald Avery, Colin MacLeod, and Maclyn McCarty – showed that when you destroy the proteins and the RNA in certain pathogenic bacteria, something still remains – and mixing that mysterious something with non-pathogenic bacteria could ‘turn’ them into pathogenic ones. But when you specifically destroy the DNA, the transformation does not happen.

The central dogma

The final nail in the coffin for proteins came in 1952 when Alfred Hershey and Martha Chase used bacteriophages – viruses that infect bacteria – and showed that when you radioactively label the phage DNA with phosphorus and its proteins with sulphur, you could find phosphorus inside the bacteria that the phage infected, but never the sulphur. The phosphorus was even present in subsequent generations of the phage produced by the infected bacteria, showing that DNA was the genetic material.

Soon afterwards, James Watson and Francis Crick proposed the double helical structure for DNA, and their model also explained how one strand helical strand can be used as a template to synthesise the other.

However, finding the answer to molecular biology’s foundational question opened a Pandora’s box of new questions. One of those questions was how the chemical information present in DNA was used to make proteins. At the time, scientists knew that proteins were the ultimate workhorses of the cell and performed all the cellular tasks. However, they did not know how the cell made proteins based on the instructions in the DNA.

In 1958, Crick, with remarkable foresight, proposed what he called the “central dogma” of molecular biology. In a paper in the journal *Symposia of the Society for Experimental Biology*, Crick wrote that “once ‘information’ has passed into protein, it cannot get out again”. He further elaborated that the core principle behind the central dogma was that the “transfer of information from nucleic acid to nucleic acid, or from nucleic acid to protein, may be possible, but transfer from protein to protein or from protein to nucleic acid is impossible.”

Crick used the general term for DNA and RNA collectively, i.e. nucleic acid, rather than DNA alone, because by that time scientists knew that some viruses used RNA as the genetic material. In all other forms of life, RNA serves a different purpose.

An unbeaten rule

Today, we know that cells use the information in the DNA to make a messenger molecule, called mRNA, which then serves as the instruction manual for the cell to make proteins.

The mRNA is a transient intermediate: a cell can stop making it if required and can degrade it if it needs to stop protein production. This way, the cell preserves the instructions in the DNA, makes a copy of the DNA into RNA, and makes protein from RNA.

But when Crick suggested the central dogma, scientists did not fully understand the role of mRNA. The DNA to RNA to protein flow sequence was only elucidated in 1961, and that sequence itself came to be known as the central dogma of molecular biology.

But one wrinkle turned up in 1970. U.S. biologists Howard Temin and David Baltimore reported the discovery of retroviruses – a new family of viruses that used RNA as the genetic material, but then made a DNA copy of it using an enzyme called reverse transcriptase, then mixed this DNA with the DNA of the host. The viruses then continued the ‘DNA to



Cells use the information in DNA to make a messenger molecule, called mRNA, which then serves as the instruction manual for the cell to make proteins. Representative illustration. IMAGE MADE WITH AI

RNA to protein’ sequence. However, the starting point was RNA, and technically, information was flowing backwards along the sequence before it flowed in the conventional way, supposedly violating the central dogma.

The discovery stirred significant debate in the scientific community, and researchers published several articles along the theme of how the central dogma had been violated. Weeks later, Crick himself wrote another paper explaining in greater detail how his guidelines for the central dogma still held, and how, even in his original 1958 paper, he had not ruled out the transfer of information within nucleic acids. He emphasised that in order to violate the central dogma, one had to find information flowing from proteins to proteins or from proteins back to either one of the nucleic acids, i.e. DNA or RNA. It was a credible argument.

Thus, for 69 years, Crick’s central dogma has been unchallenged. There have been some interesting deviations but none completely broke the rule.

A novel mechanism

Now, however, two new papers in the journals *Cell* and *Science* have reported finding a new family of bacterial reverse transcriptases. These enzymes direct cells

The discovery of DRT3b suggests that a protein can direct the synthesis of a specific DNA sequence without a nucleic-acid template, an unprecedented finding that pushes the boundaries of, but does not overturn, the central dogma of molecular biology

DNA molecules that trigger defence mechanisms, stopping the invading phage from successfully reproducing. There are several ways in which the DNA produced by DRTs stop a phage infection. Some interfere with essential phage proteins. Some activate other bacterial defence systems. Others cause the infected cell to shut itself down before the phage can multiply and spread.

The new family, called DRT3, described in these two papers, follows a novel mechanism to achieve the last outcome. According to the papers, DRT3 contains two enzymes – DRT3a and DRT3b – that work together to produce the two strands of a DNA molecule.

When this DNA accumulates inside the bacterial cell, it causes the cell to shut down and enter a dormant state,

the two DNA strands. DRT3a makes the first strand of the DNA using a bacterial RNA molecule as a template, as reverse transcriptases normally do. But the second enzyme, DRT3b, makes the second strand without using any template at all. Instead, the protein itself dictates the order of the nucleotides that determines the DNA sequence.

Interestingly, enzymes that can make DNA without a template are not new in molecular biology. One example is terminal deoxynucleotidyl transferase, which adds nucleotides to the ends of DNA without using a template. But the transferase does not add nucleotides in any specific order: if you mixed it with all the four nucleotides that make DNA in a tube, the transferase will produce a new sequence each time.

Rule challenged

DRT3b is different primarily in this regard. Although it also makes DNA without a nucleic-acid template, it does not produce a random sequence. The protein itself dictates which nucleotide is added next, producing an ordered sequence of two alternating nucleotides cytosine (C) and adenine (A), i.e. CACACACA... Despite the enzyme’s product being a simple two base pair repeat, the idea of a protein that can produce a defined DNA sequence without a nucleic acid template is unprecedented in molecular biology.

The discovery of a protein that can, by itself, dictate the sequence of nucleic acid has once again caused a stir in the scientific community.

Commentaries accompanying the work have highlighted the unusual nature of the finding and its implications for one of the foundational ideas of molecular biology. Some have gone so far as to suggest that the discovery challenges the central dogma because it appears to demonstrate information flowing from a protein back into a nucleic acid – which is just what Francis Crick had said was impossible.

However, it is important to note that while the study represents an important conceptual advance, in no way does it overturn the central dogma.

The core principle of the central dogma deals with the information lost when it is passed from nucleic acid to protein. That is, once a cell has made a protein, the protein’s amino-acid sequence will not contain enough information for the cell to rebuild the DNA sequence from which it originated. This is because there are many different DNA sequences that can encode the same protein sequence.

DRT3b also does not violate this fundamental principle governing information loss. At most, it puts a toe over the line; it does not cross it. But it does illustrate one point very beautifully: that nature is far more creative than the rules we use to describe it.

(Arun Panchapakesan is an assistant professor at the Y.R. Gaitonde Centre for AIDS Research and Education, Chennai. arun.panchapakesan@gmail.com)



Aerial view of a boat pulling a dead southern right whale calf in Puerto Madryn, Argentina. AFP

Scientists puzzled as whale calves wash up dead in Argentina

Associated Press

Investigators in Argentina are trying to solve the mystery of baby whales washing up dead in unusually high numbers along the country’s Patagonian coast.

Scores of the calf carcasses have been washing ashore around Peninsula Valdes, a major breeding ground for southern right whales in Argentina’s Chubut province. Hunted to the brink of extinction in the 19th and 20th centuries, the whales now gather in the peninsula’s sheltered waters to give birth and nurse their young.

“We’re looking into the whale calf deaths based on 23 years of monitoring that we have of this same population. That’s what allows us to say that this is an unusual event,” said Marcela Uhart, a veterinarian with the One Health Institute at the University of California, Davis, who is leading the investigation as head of the Southern Right Whale Health Monitoring Program.

The leading hypothesis is that the whale calves are suffering infections from marine bacteria that can enter their bodies through injuries inflicted by kelp gulls, Uhart said.

Researchers are searching for the dead calves by boat, plane and drone; they photograph and examine the carcasses, racing against decomposition to collect tissue samples for testing

For decades, the seabirds have pecked at whales surfacing to breathe, gorging on their skin and blubber. Adults learn to surface with only their heads exposed, keeping their backs underwater and out of reach of the gulls. Calves can not do that manoeuvre, leaving them vulnerable to attacks.

The carcasses have been washing ashore around the gulf city of Puerto Madryn, including near the central waterfront where they alarm residents and tourists. Residents have reported hundreds of them, but researchers declined to give a death toll, saying that would become clear after the season ends around late November.

Uhart and a team of biologists, veterinarians, and park rangers have been searching the area for the dead calves from shore and with boats, planes, and drones.

The work is gruesome: they photograph and examine the bodies, racing against decomposition to collect skin and organ samples for testing at a veterinary school farther north, in the city of Tandil. Bacteria have already been detected in those tissues, but researchers are still culturing samples to identify the microbes and determine whether infection was the cause of death, she said.

Even if bacteria are to blame, researchers must still determine why they have become so deadly this year.

Changes in marine conditions like warming sea temperatures, potentially linked to climate change or El Nino, could contribute to “this perfect storm where this bacteria is powerful enough to overcome the immunity of the babies and cause their deaths,” Uhart said. “So to the extent that we can, we’ll try to identify at least what factors may be triggering this event and making it so massive.”

Right whales got their name from whalers who considered them the “right” animals to hunt because they swam slowly, stayed close to shore and floated when killed, according to the International Whaling Commission, a global body tasked with regulating whaling.

Although illegal hunting continued into the 1970s, southern right whales have gradually rebounded since gaining international protection in 1935.

But their recovery remains threatened by the same pressures facing whales worldwide: declining food supplies, fishing gear entanglements, oil spills, and ship strikes.



Good, not good enough

Without raising sports standards, India should not bid for hosting the Olympics

Aspiring to host the Olympic Games in 2036, India faced a harsh reality check at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games. Compared with the previous Hangzhou Games, where it won 106 medals with a 650-plus contingent, the country won 85 medals from around 500 athletes. The aggregate fell short of an internally projected figure of around 100 medals. It is likely to invite a thorough postmortem, given the hundreds of crores of public money spent on the athletes' preparation. India laboured to 21 gold medals, seven fewer than in Hangzhou, after a late surge of 11 top honours in the last two days, driven by the exploits of archers, boxers, wrestlers, and hockey and cricket players. It tied with Uzbekistan but managed to retain its fourth spot on the strength of a bigger haul of silver. Thirteen of the gold medals came from team events, with cricket, kabaddi and hockey making a clean sweep of titles. It underscored a stark reality: the country needs to raise its bar in medal-fetching individual sports, such as athletics, swimming, gymnastics, fencing and cycling, which determine success in multi-disciplinary Games. China, the runaway winner with a massive aggregate of 341 medals, including 169 gold, secured 54 medals in swimming alone. Barring athletics, India stood nowhere.

On a brighter note, India fielded 310 debutants and recorded a marginal increase in its athlete-to-medal ratio ahead of Los Angeles 2028. Several historic performances provided reasons to rejoice. Seventeen-year-old rookie recurve archer Kumkum Mohod dismantling the Korean women's hegemony to help the archery team contribute five gold medals was a defining moment. Trap shooter Neeru Dhandu, golfer Pranavi Urs, wrestler Sujeet Kalkal and the women's hockey team, which upset Paris Olympics silver medallist China to clinch gold after 44 years, hogged the limelight. Lovlina Borgohain, Aman Sehrawat, Mirabai Chhanu, Vithya Ramraj and Gulveer Singh lived up to their billing. Boxers, wrestlers and golfers registered noticeable improvement. Olympic quota places in archery and hockey added to the excitement. Indian women catching up with men – both genders delivered 38 medals apiece – was another encouraging sign. On the flip side, India's two major contributors, athletics and shooting, which earned 24 and 15 medals, respectively, yielded 12 fewer medals than in 2023. The shuttlers slipped, while the tennis players returned empty-handed after 40 years. P.V. Sindhu and Manu Bhaker flopped. Stricter scrutiny of athletes' funding and efficient implementation of the revamped Khelo India scheme, designed with a long-term vision, are essential for course correction. Without propelling India's sporting standards, a bid to host the Olympics may become a countdown to international embarrassment.

Bird islands

India's conservation efforts must go beyond symbolism

This week, at the Desert National Park in Jaisalmer, two male Great Indian Bustards were released into the wild. It was a ceremony with considerable bureaucratic pomp; the Union and the Rajasthan Environment Ministers were in attendance. The conservation plan now has 97 birds, with nine more awaiting release. Of these, 57 are captive-bred and have produced 29 chicks this year and 24 last year. These are notable numbers for a species with a population of around 120 that has teetered on the brink of extinction for nearly half a century. It is worth recounting the bird's conservation travails. Ornithologist Salim Ali wanted it as the national bird, so that protection would follow; the Indian Board for Wildlife chose the peacock instead. Numbering about 1,260 in 1969, it dipped to 600 by 2000, and 140-175 in Rajasthan by the 2010s. Hunters, royal ones included, prized the bird, with shooting reportedly lasting into the late 1970s. The rise of irrigation in Rajasthan led to the grasslands, which were once dismissed as 'wastelands', give way to irrigated, pesticide-soaked fields and roads making the bird more vulnerable. The most recent threat came in the form of high-tension power lines. As a heavy bird, the bustard tends to fly at the same height as power lines and has poor vision. The Supreme Court in 2021 ordered that low-voltage lines in priority habitats be underground. After opprobrium from renewable energy companies, on the grounds that this compromised the economics of solar power, the Court modified the order requiring that only a subset of the power lines – those part of the bird's 'critical' habitat – be made underground.

While the cultural links of the 'Godawan' - the bird's local name - to Rajasthan's habitat are now part of government and private marketing efforts, there are several other birds that are not as fortunate. Nearly 1,256 bird species, about 11.5% of the world's total, are classified as threatened. Skylark numbers have fallen nearly 80% and Indian rollers 30% in 12 years. India's conservation policy is captive to symbolism. A tigress from Valmiki flown to Buxa; African cheetahs in enclosures; Gir's lions, confined to Saurashtra and straying in to human habitations stoking conflict; the Delhi Ridge, being planted with peepal and banyan that ecologists say do not belong to its dry ecology. The conservation ethos – on paper emphasising coexistence between the wild and human – is practically promoting islands and African-style reserves. These have merits but populations that thrive inside walls overflow into villages and fields, as India's challenges with elephants show. Landscapes, not species, ought to be the unit of conservation.

A recent World Bank forecast reveals that the global economy stands at the precipice of a silent catastrophe. A recent warning issued by Bank President Ajay Banga is stark: over the coming decade, an astonishing 1.2 billion young men and women in the Global South will reach working age, but the global economy is projected to generate no more than 400 million viable jobs. This creates a staggering deficit of 800 million opportunities in the job market, a demographic chasm of such unprecedented magnitude that it threatens to convert what should be the greatest economic dividend of the 21st century into a catalyst for widespread instability.

A failing blueprint

For decades, economic theorists have championed the demographic dividend as the primary engine for lifting developing nations out of poverty. The formula appeared straightforward: as fertility rates decline, the proportion of working-age adults relative to dependents increases, creating a temporary window of high productivity, elevated domestic savings, and rapid capital accumulation that fuelled the East Asian economic miracle in the late 20th century. Today, however, that classic blueprint is failing. Developing nations such as India are experiencing their youth bulges at a historical moment when the traditional escalators of economic mobility are stalling. The sheer velocity of demographic growth in many countries is outstripping the rate at which domestic markets, infrastructure, and institutional frameworks can absorb new labour, turning the potential dividend into a looming crisis.

Central to the dilemma is the rapid evolution of global trade, technology, and manufacturing. Historically, light manufacturing served as the indispensable bridge for low-income nations transitioning away from subsistence agriculture, absorbing millions of unskilled and semi-skilled workers into productive urban employment. Today, automation, robotics, and advanced industrial software have drastically reduced the labour intensity of manufacturing. As a result, developing nations are experiencing premature deindustrialisation: their manufacturing sectors are losing jobs before reaching the income thresholds of industrial economies of the past. Furthermore, the modern global economy increasingly rewards high-skilled, technology-driven labour, widening the chasm for millions of youth in developing countries who lack access to modern digital infrastructure, quality vocational training, or tertiary education.

There is no easy solution. The World Bank recommends unlocking private sector capital and



Shashi Tharoor

Four-term Member of Parliament (Congress) for Thiruvananthapuram, who served nearly three decades at the United Nations, where he rose to the position of Under-Secretary-General. He has also been Minister of State for External Affairs and for Human Resource Development in the Government of India and is the bestselling author, among others, of 'Pax Indica: India and the World of the 21st century'

dismantling the regulatory sclerosis that throttles domestic enterprise in many developing economies. Potential entrepreneurs face prohibitive costs of capital, erratic regulatory environments and predatory taxation. Complex legal frameworks and weak property rights scare away long-term foreign direct investment, confining capital to speculative assets rather than employment-generating ventures. Simplifying regulatory regimes, establishing transparent governance structures, and bolstering institutional integrity are essential preconditions for creating environments where small and medium-sized enterprises, the main engines of global job creation, can launch, grow, and hire.

India lags here, but does better in improving infrastructure, another key recommendation. A small business cannot compete in global supply chains, nor can it grow locally, if it suffers from routine power failures or exorbitant logistics costs caused by dilapidated roads and port congestion. Modernising physical and digital infrastructure serves a dual economic purpose: the construction and deployment phase itself absorbs massive quantities of immediate labour, while the resulting assets lower the cost of doing business across the economy.

Sector-specific strategies are ideal

Within this broader macroeconomic overhaul, targeted sector-specific strategies offer the most realistic pathway toward mass labour absorption. Agriculture still remains the largest employer in the developing world. Transitioning from low-yield subsistence farming to high-value, technology-enabled agri-tech and commercial agribusiness can transform rural economies. By investing in cold-chain logistics, localised food processing, and climate-resilient farming techniques, nations can create sophisticated rural value chains that offer meaningful, remunerative employment to young people, reducing the desperate tide of distress migration to the cities.

Health care and the broader care economy offer other possibilities for employment expansion. The demand for trained health-care workers, nurses, community health personnel, and elder-care specialists is exploding. Investing in health human resources delivers a powerful double dividend: it creates millions of resilient, non-outsourcable domestic jobs (predominantly for young women who are often excluded from formal labour markets) while simultaneously building the human capital necessary to sustain long-term national productivity.

Similarly, tourism and culture offer an extraordinary vehicle for decentralised job creation. Tourism is inherently labour-intensive, engages semi-skilled and unskilled workers and is resistant to total automation. It possesses a

A widening jobs gap threatens the promise of demographic dividends; the Global South faces an unprecedented employment challenge

America's new-age military populism takes shape



Harsh V. Pant

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Vivek Mishra

Deputy Director, Strategic Studies Programme at the Observer Research Foundation

America's military transformation under the Trump administration combines technological reform with the politics of populism

to place technological superiority *vis-à-vis* China front and centre. Among the other steps announced to overhaul the U.S. military is the "Fortress America" project, intended to redesign energy and cyber connectivity so that U.S. bases become self-sufficient in both electricity grids and cyber command. Towards realigning the recruitment system, the Pentagon will now work with five select universities to establish a new corps of cadets. The absence of any Ivy League institution is telling of the Trump administration's long war against elite educational institutions and the values that new-age Republicans associate with them.

Perhaps the most consequential move was Mr. Hegseth's announcement of a 20% cut in general and flag officer positions across the armed forces by January 1, 2027 – double the reduction he announced in 2025. Mr. Hegseth's broad definition of "redundant force structure", which he has used as a pretext to trim the military's senior ranks, now also extends to ending new tenured appointments of civilian academics at military service academies. Besides these measures, the decision to establish an Office of Religious Affairs (ORA), reporting directly to the Secretary of War and providing religious support and spiritual readiness, bears all the hallmarks of Republican evangelical outreach writ large.

Drivers behind the overhaul

Behind the overhaul of the DoW lies a convergence of competing drivers: populism, rapid technological evolution, cultural revivalism, assessments of comparative military might and capability, and a race against time. Americans view the changes differently on each metric. For instance, while most see the decision to set up the Autonomous Warfare Command as a necessity, the removal of senior military ranks has drawn flak – as a decapitation of the military leadership from within. The departure of the Army Secretary, Dan Driscoll, in August was the culmination of the urge to purge that Mr. Hegseth has evinced.

Mr. Hegseth's measures, taken together, offer a decidedly mixed picture. The U.S. is approaching the end of a military era that began with the Reagan administration's sweeping military-industrial transformation in the

uniquely broad multiplier effect, driving revenues down to local transport providers, hospitality workers, artisans, and historical preservation efforts. Strategic investments in sustainable tourism infrastructure and international destination marketing translates directly into widespread employment.

Manufacturing, too, must be reimaged. Modern light assembly, green-transition manufacturing (such as the production of solar components, electric two-wheelers, and energy-efficient materials) and decentralised production networks can still absorb substantial labour if paired with agile skill-building programmes.

History demonstrates that when vast cohorts of educated, energetic, and ambitious young people are denied access to productive economic life, the resulting frustration erodes trust in governments, fuels social polarisation, and creates fertile ground for extremist or criminal ideologies and civil unrest. In an interconnected world, failure to generate livelihoods in the Global South will inevitably accelerate forced migration flows toward the Global North, exacerbating political tensions worldwide.

Preventing prolonged youth unemployment from leading to global catastrophe requires an unprecedented alignment of international finance, domestic political courage, and private sector dynamism. Developed economies and multilateral financial institutions must facilitate affordable, long-term development financing and technology transfers, while developing nations must undertake the hard, often politically painful work of institutional reform. The global economy possesses the financial resources and technological tools required to meet this challenge. But can the international community muster the collective resolve to build an inclusive global order where every young person is afforded a fair opportunity to work, contribute, and thrive? In today's climate this writer would not count on it.

As the world's most populous nation, India sits at the epicentre of this dynamic, adding millions of young entrants to its workforce each year while grappling with an economy that has struggled to match GDP growth with employment creation. The nation's immediate challenge, in a dwindling demographic window, includes matching skills to markets, persistent underemployment, low female labour force participation, and an agrarian sector that still absorbs nearly half the population despite producing just 16% of GDP (FY24). India, with a median age under 30, must move toward labour-absorbing value creation. Otherwise its celebrated demographic dividend could collapse into a demographic disaster.

Reform and strategic necessity

The problem is that the Trump administration's sense of urgency has too often conflated the politics of populism with the imperatives of military reform. In the process, the distinction between political messaging and strategic necessity-and, at times, between friend and foe-has become blurred.

Mr. Hegseth's rhetoric about creating forces with "no fannies, no trannies, no beards, no weirdos", alongside his proposal for mandatory testosterone-deficiency testing in the annual health screenings of personnel aged 30 years and above, takes the notion of a "warrior ethos" into territory that appears increasingly disconnected from the demands of modern warfare. At a time when technological superiority, automation, artificial intelligence and precision systems are reshaping the character of conflict, military effectiveness cannot be reduced to an increasingly narrow conception of physical warriorhood.

Yet, it would be a mistake to allow the excesses of this rhetoric to obscure the genuine opportunities before the U.S.. President Trump's two terms have coincided with an extraordinary acceleration in technological change, creating both significant challenges and important possibilities for American military power. The re-establishment of the Space Command in 2019 was one such consequential step, while the more recent announcement of AutoWarCom could, if pursued seriously, have transformative implications for the organisation and the deployment of military power.

The larger task is to ensure that such initiatives are driven by the requirements of future warfare rather than subsumed by the vocabulary of populism. For the world's most powerful military, the stakes are ultimately too high for political theatre to substitute for strategic clarity.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Push Russia towards peace

It is disquieting that inspite of appeals, proddings including warnings by a raft of global leaders and organisations, there is no indication on the part of the Russian President Vladimir

Putin to halt the hostilities against Ukraine that have entered the fifth year. (Inside pages, October 4). The relentless aerial attacks by Russia have caused colossal destruction. Before the situation spins out of

control, it is incumbent upon the key countries which profess supremacy in warfare to step up various forms of pressure on Russia to end the war.
V. Johan Dhanakumar,
Chennai

Singeetham Srinivasa Rao

In the passing of Singeetham Srinivasa Rao, Indian cinema has lost a legendary director who envisioned concepts far ahead of his time. With extraordinary command of

various crafts, he created unique and pathbreaking films. His landmark projects inspired a generation of film-makers. Indian cinema has also lost a celluloid innovator who explored

almost every genre with limited resources.
Satish Reddy Kanaganti,
Tipparthi, Nalgonda, Telangana

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address and the full name.

Disabled citizens and the future of AI

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Decline in India's sunflower oil imports in September

36 in per cent, Indian sunflower oil imports fell in September to their lowest level in more than four years after the Ukraine war disrupted shipments. India's sunflower oil imports plunged 36% from a month earlier to 103,000 metric tonnes in September, dealers' average estimates showed. PTI

Years after which Odisha is holding student union polls

8 Students' union elections will be held in public colleges and universities across Odisha on October 15, ending an eight-year hiatus, Higher Education Minister Suryabanshi Suraj said on Monday. "The election is aimed at preparing the leadership for the future from the college level," he said. PTI

High schools disrupted due to French student protests

413 France high school students protest disrupted lessons at 413 of the country's 3,700 schools on Monday, the Education Ministry said, down from the number of schools affected last week. It said the drop was due to "sustained dialogue with high school students". AFP

Death toll from flooding in Thailand since mid-September

31 Thai authorities on Monday warned of more rain and flash flooding as the death toll from floods across the country since mid-September rose to 31. Thunderstorms, strong winds and heavy rain are expected across much of upper Thailand from Monday through Wednesday. AP

Spain's crude oil imports from January and August

2.32 million metric tonnes. Between January and August, Spain imported 2.32 million metric tonnes of crude from Venezuela, the highest for this period since the 2.39 million tonnes imported in 2006, according to data. REUTERS
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Why is Buxa bringing tigers back?

Why was Buxa chosen for reintroduction? How will the tigers be reintroduced? Why was Valmiki chosen as the source? What are the challenges? Can Buxa sustain a tiger population? How has tiger reintroduction worked in India? Why did tigers disappear from Buxa? How will the reintroduced tigers be monitored?

EXPLAINER

Shiv Sahay Singh

The story so far:

In October 2, a three-year-old tigress, T138, was released in Buxa Tiger Reserve in West Bengal, marking the beginning of a phased programme to reintroduce tigers and establish a viable, self-sustaining population in the reserve. Three more tigers are likely to be introduced to the reserve, which has not recorded much presence of tigers over the past few years.

The tigress was translocated from Bihar's Valmiki Tiger Reserve and released in the presence of Union Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav and West Bengal Chief Minister Suvenhu Adhikari.

Initially, the tigress would be kept in an enclosed area of about 2.3 hectares to allow the animal to acclimatise to its new surroundings before it is released into the wider reserve. T138 would be subject to intensive post-release monitoring using a combination of telemetry, camera trapping and field-based monitoring to assess her movement, adaptation, health and behaviour.

The release of the tigress is not merely about bringing tigers back to Buxa, but its "objective is to create the conditions in which a tiger population can establish, breed and ultimately become viable and self-sustaining," PIB said in a statement.

Why is Buxa Tiger Reserve significant?

Buxa was declared a tiger reserve in 1983 and is the 15 th tiger reserve in the country. Buxa Tiger Reserve is situated in the Alipurduar Sub-division of Jalpaiguri District, West Bengal.

With an area of 760.87 sq. km, the reserve stretches over a length of 50 km from west to east and 35 km from north to south. The reserve has corridor connectivity across the border with the



Three-year-old tigress, T138, walks through the forest after being released into the wild at Buxa Tiger Reserve, in Alipurduar, West Bengal. PTI

forests of Bhutan in the north; to the east, it has linkages with the Kochugaon forests, Manas Tiger Reserve, and to the West with the Jaldapara National Park.

One of the reasons for low tiger density has been changes in the habitat due to increasing anthropogenic pressure. "Over the decades, however, habitat degradation and fragmentation, changes in land use and decline in prey availability have affected the ecological conditions required to sustain a resident tiger population. The Reserve subsequently witnessed a prolonged absence of a stable resident tiger population," a PIB statement said.

Why was Valmiki Tiger Reserve selected for bringing the tigress?

The National Tiger Conservation Authority found that there were no tigers at Buxa, Dampa and Palamu tiger reserves; it initiated a programme of reintroduction of tigers in 2018, which has resulted in the reintroduction of tigers at Buxa. Scientists and forest officials were looking for a habitat similar to Buxa from which the tiger may be brought to the reserve. Bihar's Valmiki Tiger Reserve, which lies in the easternmost part of the Terai Arc Landscape, was considered suitable for tiger augmentation because of the similarities in terrain with Buxa.

West Bengal has a thriving tiger population in the Sundarbans, the only mangrove forest in the world to have tigers. As per the last census, the Indian Sundarbans is home to about 100 tigers in the unique mangrove ecosystem. However, translocating tigers from the Sundarbans to Buxa may not have worked because of the vast differences in the terrain and the habitat.

What has been the experience with reintroduction of tigers?

Tiger 'reintroduction' done in India is the first such scientific endeavour in the world, says NTCA. Reintroducing tigers in the Indian context means establishing a tiger population in an area which was part of its historical range but from where it has gone locally extinct.

The tiger reintroduction has been a successful collaborative venture between the NTCA, State governments, and the Wildlife Institute of India (WII), with numbers of tigers increasing in reserves where the exercise was carried out.

The reintroduction started in 2008 when tigers were successfully reintroduced in Sariska (Rajasthan) and Panna (Madhya Pradesh) Tiger Reserves. The tiger reintroduction programme has been carried out across 12 tiger reserves in less than two decades.

The success of the programme, however, has not been uniform across the reserves.

A publication titled "Reintroduction & Population Recovery of Tigers in India: Field Experiences & Key Learnings" released by NTCA and WII earlier this year has pointed out that relocation of tigers in Satkosia Tiger Reserve posed several challenges. "The translocated tigers encountered difficulties in adapting to the new environment, and the landscape experienced considerable human-tiger conflict, including incidents of livestock depredation and negative local responses," the report said.

The NTCA website also added that in the past there have been few examples of tiger 'release' (Dongarpur in Rajasthan and in Russia) which were not successful owing to several factors.

Keeping these challenges in mind, the NTCA has prepared a protocol on tiger re-introduction. The protocol deals with aims and objectives of reintroduction, constitution of team, pre-project activities, conducting feasibility study, selection and evaluation of site, suitability of release stock of tigers, socio-economic requirements, preparation for release and post-release activities.

What are the challenges?

Buxa Tiger Reserve had not had a resident tiger for several years, though on some occasions tigers have been recorded in the winter months.

The reserve is dotted with settlements and surrounded by revenue villages and tea estates. The State government has convinced about 300 families to relocate so that they can make the tiger reintroduction exercise successful. Wildlife, particularly elephants, has been threatened by linear infrastructure including a railway line, resulting in the deaths of hundreds of pachyderms over the decade. Because the region lies close to Bhutan, heavy commercial traffic on the road connecting Bhutan and West Bengal through Buxa poses an additional concern.

THE GIST

▼ A three-year-old tigress from Bihar's Valmiki Tiger Reserve has been released in Buxa Tiger Reserve as part of a phased programme to establish a viable, self-sustaining tiger population

▼ Valmiki was chosen because its terrain is similar to Buxa, while translocation from the Sundarbans was considered unsuitable due to differences in habitat and terrain

▼ The reintroduction faces challenges including habitat degradation, low prey availability, human settlements, linear infrastructure and heavy commercial traffic through the reserve

Why are States divided over the mining amendment?

Amendment curbs States' fiscal powers, but their responses vary with dependence and political alignment

Safira Hussain
Sanjay Kumar

In a federal country like India, differences between the Centre and the States over certain issues are not unusual. One such instance recently arose over the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026, passed by Parliament.

Under the amended Act, the Centre's regulatory powers over mining have been expanded to cover not only mines and mineral development but also mineral-bearing lands. It bars States from imposing fresh taxes on mineral rights and mineral-bearing lands, except under conditions prescribed by the Union government. It also cancels mineral taxes imposed by States but not fully collected before the Act came into force.

Mines and minerals are a subject over which legislative powers are divided between the Centre and the States. State governments are empowered to regulate

mines and minerals under entry 23 of the State List, but this power is subject to central legislation as per entry 54 of the Union List. The latter entry gives Parliament the discretion to determine the extent of authority over mining regulation and development in the public interest. The Constitution also gives States powers to tax mineral rights and land through entries 50 and 49 of the State List. The recent amendment draws on the Centre's regulatory authority over mineral development to place new limits on these State-level taxing powers. So, the issue widens from mining regulation to the fiscal autonomy of mineral-rich States.

The amended provisions contradict the constitutional position articulated by the Supreme Court in 2024. The court held that States can tax mineral rights, subject to Parliament's power to limit this in the public interest, while their power to tax mineral-bearing land cannot be curtailed through Parliament's powers under Entry 54. The Centre has argued that uneven and multiple State-level taxes raise the

cost of domestic minerals, prompting industries to turn to imports and placing an additional burden on the exchequer. By invalidating unrecovered past dues, the law hits at the potential source of revenue for States, narrowing the prospective mineral-related revenue for some of the major mineral-bearing States.

The fiscal stakes

Mineral-related receipts account for 85% of non-tax revenue in Jharkhand and 80% in Odisha, compared with 48% in Karnataka, 41% in Madhya Pradesh and 39% in Rajasthan. Telangana and Chhattisgarh are less dependent, with mineral receipts making up 11% and 6%, respectively. For Jharkhand and Odisha, restrictions on the ability to impose or retain mineral-related levies therefore have significant fiscal implications, while the immediate impact may be smaller in Telangana and Chhattisgarh. Odisha is particularly revealing in this regard. Despite deriving a substantial share of its non-tax revenue from minerals, the State

has not responded with a unified position. The Opposition has demanded a special Assembly session. The BJP-led State government, however, has rejected the demand and argued that the amendment would not harm Odisha's mineral revenues. Telangana, where mineral receipts account for only about 11% of non-tax revenue, has also joined other non-NDA-ruled States intending to move the Supreme Court against the amendment. While Karnataka, Telangana, Himachal Pradesh and Kerala are planning to challenge the law in the Supreme Court, arguing that the restrictions on State taxation of mineral rights and mineral-bearing land undermine States' fiscal powers and federalism, Kerala has additionally argued that treating mineral-bearing land in this manner gives the Centre wider powers over areas such as the State's coastal and forest regions. Jharkhand has also raised objections, with the Chief Minister warning that the loss of revenue from mineral taxes could affect social-security schemes benefiting millions because the amended Act renders certain uncollected past dues invalid. By contrast, there has been no comparable challenge from States such as Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan or Chhattisgarh so far.

The political geography of this discontent points to an interesting feature of Indian federalism. Even when the underlying concern is perceived erosion of States' fiscal space, the extent to which it becomes a federal issue varies across States. Mineral dependence creates a

material stake, while political alignment may influence whether that stake translates into an organised federal challenge.

India's fiscal federal structure comes across as asymmetric rather than purely decentralised. It gives greater taxation powers to the Centre while placing greater expenditure responsibilities on the States in several areas. The Centre has significant influence over borrowing and transfers to the States, which restricts State autonomy when they depend on the Centre's transfers or require its approval for borrowing. How much fiscal autonomy do States possess, and how far can the Union influence it often becomes a bone of contention between them.

The evolving Indian federal dynamic is marked by push and pull between the central authority and States' autonomy. Conflicts between the Centre and the States over legislative jurisdiction, fiscal resources, administrative control, and even foreign policy engagements have surfaced time and again, be it over the GST compensation, the terms of reference for Finance Commissions, the National Education Policy, the Citizenship Amendment Act, and proposed amendments to All-India Services rules, to list a few. This amendment therefore adds another fault line to India's continuing Centre-State contest over legislative authority and fiscal autonomy. (Safira Hussain is currently associated with Lokniti-CSDS; Sanjay Kumar is a Professor and an election analyst)

INBRIEF



Saudia Group's flyadeal plans network expansion in India

flyadeal, Saudia Group's low-cost carrier is planning major network expansion in India to provide efficient air connectivity between various locations of India and the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia. The airline after starting a five times a week flight to Hyderabad in July, has introduced a flight connecting Mumbai from Riyadh starting October 3. Now plans are afoot to connect cities like Lucknow, Calicut, Delhi, Chennai and even Kolkata said the airline's acting Chief Executive Officer Sanjiv Kapoor, who is also Executive Vice President Strategies at Saudia Group. "The 100% increase in jet fuel prices in the last six months has slowed down expansion plans. We will scale it up once prices stabilise," Mr. Kapoor said. flyadeal now operates five times a week between Mumbai and Riyadh using a fleet of A320neo aircraft, adding more than 7,400 seats each month between the two cities.

AMI to get 20,000 more NVIDIA Rubin GPUs for India, Malaysia

AM Intelligence (AMI), the AI infrastructure platform set up by Greenko promoters, has placed two more orders for a total of 20,000 NVIDIA Rubin GPUs to be deployed in Malaysia and India. These are in addition to AMI's commitment in August, for 9,000 NVIDIA Rubin GPUs at its first AI factory in Hyderabad. The follow-on capacity of around 70 megawatts (MW) will be deployed in Malaysia and India with delivery scheduled for Q2 2027, AMI said. "Both facilities will be built to the same architecture standard as the Hyderabad AI factory, integrating the NVIDIA Vera Rubin platform with high-throughput RDMA over Converged Ethernet (RoCE) networking for fast, efficient data movement, alongside advanced storage systems," Chairman Anil Chalamalasetty said. Each site is engineered for high rack power density and liquid cooled throughput, allowing the infrastructure to accommodate successive generations of AI silicon within the same physical footprint, he said in a release on Monday.

Rural porting war heats up as telcos chase users via richer retailer sops

Vallari Sanzgiri
MUMBAI

Telecom operators are ramping up incentives for rural retailers to attract subscribers through Mobile Number Portability (MNP), signalling a shift in the competitive dynamics.

While keeping MNP payouts broadly unchanged, telcos are offering additional incentives equivalent to a month's re-charge or free demo plans for meeting specified port-in targets, according to an IIFL Capital rural survey on telecom trends.

In parts of Rajasthan, retailers received ₹299-349 per MNP after the first five port-ins, effectively equivalent to a free monthly re-charge. In rural Maharashtra, retailers are eligible for a free demo pack from a telco after completing more than three MNPs.

This marks a sharp shift from the research firm's 2018 rural survey, when operators offered ₹200-210 per port-in only after retailers crossed 50 port-ins.

The new incentives come amid intensifying competition among Bharti Airtel, Reliance Jio and Vodafone Idea (Vi) to expand their subscriber bases, industry sources told *businessline*. Vi's recent move to offer free international roaming on select plans is another sign of the changing competitive landscape, they said. While the slowdown in incentives had earlier been attributed to

Telcos are offering free demo plans for meeting specified port-in targets, according to a survey

the market becoming increasingly duopolistic, industry sources said the renewed push reflects operators' efforts to protect and grow their subscriber bases.

"Increase in incentives makes sense since the market has become more competitive now that Vodafone Idea is in a better position and can be more aggressive. The stakes are a little higher. Almost every operator has an incentive to attract and retain more subscribers," said Mahesh Uppal, Director, Comm-First (India). Following the AGR (Adjusted Gross Revenue; a metric used by the DoT to calculate licence fees and spectrum usage charges owed by telecom operator) relief granted to Vi earlier this year, the operator has sought to reinvent itself in the telecom and digital spaces.

Generally, too, MNP activity has increased. The number of SIM port-ins across India rose from 14.46 million in May to 15.83 million in August, according to TRAI data. However, August remained below the 15.98 million port-ins recorded in January.

(The writer is with The Hindu businessline)

MSMEs seek curbs on metal price surge

Industry body says timely intervention is essential to contain input-cost pressures and protect competitiveness of Coimbatore's MSME sector

M. Soundariya Preetha
COIMBATORE

Coimbatore's Micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs), already reeling under higher prices of diesel, furnace oil and LPG, are facing mounting pressure from a sharp rise in the cost of key raw materials such as steel, pig iron, copper and aluminium.

The Joint Council of Associations of Coimbatore, in a memorandum submitted to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, said the "acute and unprecedented" increase in raw material prices was placing severe stress on MSMEs.

While Wholesale Price Index (WPI) data indicate fluctuations and even a decline in steel prices, actual market conditions remain "adverse", the council said. Steel prices have ri-



While WPI data indicate fluctuations and even a decline in steel prices, actual market conditions remain "adverse". FILE PHOTO

sen by around ₹8,000-₹10,000 a tonne between August and September this year, it added. The council urged the government to constitute a Price Monitoring Committee for steel to track availability and prices and prevent hoarding, cartelisation and abnormal price increases.

It also sought withdrawal of applicable import and safeguard duties on steel for six months and

deferment of the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) requirements and Quality Control Orders for imported steel until March 2027.

To address shortages of non-ferrous metals, the council called for measures to encourage imports of copper and aluminium scrap.

It also urged the Ministry of Steel to explore setting up a SAIL depot in Coimbatore.

'SEBI to partly reverse derivative settlement rules after pushback'

Reuters
MUMBAI

India's markets regulator SEBI is likely to stop using closing auctions to calculate derivatives settlement prices for at least a year, two sources with direct knowledge of the matter said, in a partial reversal of new mechanisms it has introduced for setting the closing prices of key stocks and derivative contracts.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India in August introduced a new

mechanism called the closing auction session, or CAS, for stocks that have futures and options contracts linked to them.

Under this system, a short auction at the end of the trading day helps determine the closing price of a stock. The new process, similar to that used in global markets including the U.S. and Hong Kong, has led to sharp swings in derivatives prices on expiry days, prompting the regulator to review it.

In a post on social media



SEBI said it had received 20,000 suggestions to tweak the rules.

platform X over the weekend, SEBI said it had received 20,000 suggestions to tweak the rules in res-

Amid 'volatile' ATF prices, IndiGo ups fuel surcharge for third time

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

IndiGo has raised its fuel surcharge for the third time since the West Asia conflict pushed up aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices, with the revised levy applicable to bookings made from 0001 hours on October 6, 2026.

The airline said on Monday that ATF prices have remained volatile amid heightened geopolitical tensions in West Asia, with the latest month-on-month increase exceeding 14%. Fuel costs are now among the highest seen in a decade, IndiGo said, adding that ATF accounts for a significant share of its operating expenses.

IndiGo said the latest increase represents only a partial pass-through of higher fuel costs. A full pass-through, it said, would have required a significantly steeper increase.

The revised surcharge ranges from ₹375 to ₹1,300

The revised surcharge ranges from ₹375-1,300 for domestic flights, based on distance

for domestic flights, depending on distance. For journeys of up to 500 km, the charge has been raised to ₹375 from ₹275 under the schedule introduced in April. Flights between 501 km and 1,000 km will attract ₹600, against ₹400 earlier, while the charge for 1,001-1,500 km rises to ₹900 from ₹600.

For flights covering 1,501-2,000 km, the surcharge increases to ₹1,150 from ₹800, while journeys beyond 2,000 km will attract ₹1,300, up from ₹950.

International surcharges have also been revised. The charge for SAARC destinations has increased to ₹1,000 and ₹3,000 across the applicable distance bands, from ₹900 and ₹2,500 earlier.

Cygni Energy, Indus Towers ink MoU for telecom infra solutions

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Energy-storage technology and manufacturing company Cygni Energy and telecom tower firm Indus Towers have decided to explore collaboration on sourcing energy storage solutions for telecom infrastructure in the country.

The collaboration will include plans to establish Battery Energy Storage System (BESS) manufacturing capacity of up to 1.5 GWh to address the evolving energy requirements of telecom infrastructure, Cygni Energy said on Monday following the signing of an MoU with Indus.

The companies are also expected to evaluate advanced battery technologies for telecom applications, aimed at enhancing reliability, improving energy efficiency and enabling more sustainable telecom operations, it said.

es by the end of this month. A SEBI spokesperson did not respond to a request for comment.

The new approach would align India more closely with US and European markets, where derivatives settlement is often determined using dedicated pricing mechanisms, including volume-weighted average prices over set trading periods, rather than a single closing auction. The regulator had also proposed in its review plans in September to stop

publishing the indicative value of an index and publish only the indicative prices of individual stocks during the 10-minute CAS window, arguing that the index value was still being determined.

The majority of feedback comments it received said that sophisticated trading desks could reconstruct those values independently and that removing them would reduce transparency without addressing manipulation concerns, the sources said.

U.S. IRS imposes \$32,350 penalty on Dr. Reddy's arm

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

A step-down wholly owned U.S. subsidiary of pharma major Dr. Reddy's Laboratories has been levied a \$32,350.20 penalty by the U.S. Internal Revenue Service (IRS).

The penalty on Dr. Reddy's Laboratories Inc., the subsidiary, is due to misclassification of fiscal year reference at tax payment. The Hyderabad-based parent company said citing the order from the Department of Treasury, Internal Revenue Service, Cincinnati. The company received the final transcript dated September 25, 2026, from the De-



Mmisclassification of fiscal year reference at tax payment invited the penalty, DRL said.

partment, on October 2, 2026 classifying an amount \$32,350.20 as a penalty levied by IRS.

Based on its evaluation, of the order, there is no material impact on financials, operations or other activities of the company, Dr. Reddy's said in a filing on Saturday.

Deposit growth gets FCNR(B) boost, yet trails credit expansion

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

Deposits of Indian commercial banks rose 15.3% year-on-year (y-o-y) to ₹173.5 lakh crore in the September quarter of FY27, from ₹150.5 lakh crore a year earlier, according to an analysis of business updates released by 21 banks. On a sequential basis, deposits grew 5.2% during the quarter.

The increase was aided by strong inflows into foreign currency non-resident (FCNR-B) deposits. However, deposit growth was not broad-based, with the share of low-cost current and savings account

(CASA) deposits at several lenders remaining flat or declining y-o-y. This points to continued reliance on term deposits and bulk funding

Most banks reported quarter-on-quarter deposit growth of 4-6 %. Kotak Mahindra Bank was a notable outlier, with deposits rising 13.7% sequentially. Banks that attracted significant FCNR(B) inflows generally reported stronger deposit growth, with HDFC Bank and South Indian Bank among those recording above-average growth.

HDFC Bank's deposits grew 19% y-o-y, outpacing its loan growth of more than 15 % and providing



Report card: Kotak Mahindra Bank was a notable outlier, with deposits rising 13.7% sequentially. REUTERS

some relief on the funding front. Despite stronger deposit mobilisation, banks continued to expand their loan books faster than deposits. Aggregate advances

of the 21 banks grew 21.4 % y-o-y to ₹149.6 lakh crore in Q2 FY27. On a sequential basis, advances rose more than 6.25%, outpacing deposit growth by around

one percentage point.

The surge in FCNR(B) inflows, estimated at about \$137 billion, was therefore insufficient to materially ease pressure on banks' funding metrics. The aggregate credit-deposit (CD) ratio rose to 86.3 % in the September quarter from 82% a year earlier, reflecting the persistent gap between credit and deposit growth.

Of the 21 banks analysed, only HDFC Bank and Bank of India reported a decline in their CD ratios, although the moderation was modest. HDFC Bank recorded the sharper improvement, with its CD ratio easing to 95.7 % from

98.8 % a year earlier.

The stronger business momentum is also expected to reflect in the September-quarter earnings. Analysts expect banks to report healthy profit growth, supported by robust loan expansion and stable asset quality.

Lenders that attracted sizeable FCNR(B) deposits could face some pressure on net interest margins (NIMs) because of the temporary increase in funding costs. However, earnings are expected to remain supported by balance-sheet growth and contained credit costs.

(The writer is with The Hindu businessline)

Time running out for EU to deliver Draghi reforms



Big shortfall: As of July, the EU had delivered on only 15.7% of Draghi's proposals in full. REUTERS

Reuters
LONDON

Time is running out for the European Union to deliver the economic reforms set out by former European Central Bank chief Mario Draghi two years ago. If the bloc fails, it faces the prospect of long-term comparative decline, becoming an also-ran on the world stage.

The bloc set the end of 2027 as its deadline for delivering key elements of Draghi's blueprint, which include a complete single market featuring capital markets and energy unions, more common borrowing and fewer requirements for unanimous member state support for major reforms.

As of July, the European Union had delivered on only 15.7% of Draghi's proposals in full, with about a further 40% partially tackled, according to the European Policy Innovation Council.

If you zero in on the most radical - and thus the most important - measures such as single capital and energy markets, the picture is even worse. The EU has successfully legislated on just 3% of those, according to French think tank Institut Montaigne. The European Commission can only push through these with all member states' agreement - a daunting task.

Europe's upcoming election calendar could make that much harder. Governments facing voters are unlikely to be keen to relinquish more sovereignty, and if these elections produce less reform-minded leaders, the fabric of EU integration could start to unravel.

Heading to the polls

France is in the spotlight with elections in April. The EU is already scrambling to finalise the bloc's next long-term budget, covering 2028-2034, before these polls for fear that they could deliver a far-right government headed by Marine Le Pen.

While Le Pen's National Rally has abandoned its ambition to leave the EU, it has still indicated that it wants to curb France's contribution to the bloc's budget and opt out of key parts of energy policy, while reimposing border controls.

Meanwhile, Spain is now coming to the polls sooner than expected. Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez on Monday called an early election for November 29 after parliament rejected the government's housing decrees last week amid significant public protests.

Votes in Italy and Poland come later in 2027. They could further complicate reform efforts as leaders may be loath to support potentially prudent reform measures, which require relinquishing national sovereignty, right before going to the polls.

Then there is Germany. While the country's ruling coalition is in power until 2029, surging support for the far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD) - which has supported closer ties with Russia and severe immigration restrictions - could stall reform efforts in the bloc's largest economy.

Germany, under Chancellor Friedrich Merz, has, up until now, been more ambitious in its reform agenda than most of its neighbours. Since taking office last year, he has loosened Germany's "debt brake" - a fiscal rule that had long stymied growth - to allow for sharply higher defence spending and the creation of a €500 billion infrastructure fund. This was followed up with plans to upgrade the country's electricity grid alongside pension, tax and labour reforms.

The spending has been popular, but reform measures, such as cracking down on workers' sick days and welfare abuse, and gradually raising the state pension age, emphatically are not - as evidenced by recent election results.

"The main takeaway is that Germans don't want reforms and want to stay either in a never-changing present or return to the past," wrote Carsten Brzeski, chief economist at ING, after the ruling Christian Democratic Union (CDU) suffered heavy losses in regional elections amid the surge in support for the AfD.

While the AfD has yet to win any governing majorities and should struggle to find coalition partners, its rapid rise in the past decade to become Germany's highest-polling party cannot be dismissed - especially as its popularity could push the ruling party to slow down on reforms that appear to reduce national sovereignty.

A palpable sense of urgency is present among EU officials.

"Where projects are in Europe's strategic interests, we need to massively accelerate," European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen said last month in her annual "State of the Union" address to the European Parliament.

How Telangana's MeeSeva migration to open source makes for a case study

The State's move from Oracle to open-source PostgreSQL, completed in April 2026, shows both the potential savings and the technical and administrative hurdles involved in moving mission-critical government systems away from proprietary software

NEWS ANALYSIS

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

When Telangana's MeeSeva platform moved from Oracle to the open-source PostgreSQL database in April 2026, it was more than a change in the software running behind a government website.

It marked an attempt to move a critical public-service platform away from a proprietary database after about 15 years of use.

The migration story could also offer a case study for other governments looking to reduce recurring software costs. Telangana's Commissioner of Electronic Services Delivery, Ravikiran Tirumala, said in a LinkedIn post that Oracle licensing and maintenance for MeeSeva had cost about ₹10 crore a year and that the migration would eliminate that recurring expenditure.

Journey so far

The effort began in 2023, when the State started examining how to reduce its spending on proprietary software licences.

The project subsequently went through multiple government committees before the migration was completed in April 2026.

The technical details of the migration were presented at IndiaFOSS 2026 by Hari P. Kiran, founder and CEO of OpenSource DB, a PostgreSQL-focused services company. Mr. Kiran led the database migration on the ground.

French database expert Gilles Darold, creator of the open-source Ora2Pg migration tool used in the project, also wrote an article documenting the migration.

He said MeeSeva had been running on Oracle for 15 years, handled about 80,000 government-to-citizen transactions a day and was moved to PostgreSQL with less than four



Quality control: The team had to establish that a new database could continue to support a critical citizen-facing platform without compromising data integrity or performance. FILE PHOTO

hours of downtime.

Why does it matter?

Government technology systems often remain in place for years. Once applications and databases are built around a particular technology, moving away from it can become difficult because of accumulated code, dependencies, testing requirements and institutional familiarity.

MeeSeva provides more than 500 government-to-citizen and government-to-business services. Mr. Kiran said the migration covered more than 85 micro-services and involved three Oracle servers and 1,939 tables. In simple terms, the exercise involved moving the database infrastructure supporting the platform while ensuring that the individual software components using the database continued to function.

The task, therefore, was not simply to install PostgreSQL and switch off Oracle. The team had to establish that a new database could continue to support a critical citizen-facing platform without compromising data integrity or performance.

In a LinkedIn post announcing the completion, Mr. Kiran said MeeSeva had handled nearly 200 million transactions across 5,000 service centres and that the migration resulted



MeeSeva has handled nearly 200 million transactions across 5,000 service centres. The migration resulted in no data loss and no critical issues after migration

What is PostgreSQL?

Oracle Database is proprietary software developed by U.S.-based technology giant Oracle. PostgreSQL is an open-source relational database that can be used without a proprietary database licence fee. The distinction is important in the Telangana case because the State identified Oracle licensing as a recurring expenditure. Open source, however, does not mean that running a system is cost-free. Organisations still need infrastructure, engineers, security, monitoring, backups, support and maintenance. In Telangana's case, the attraction was therefore not simply that PostgreSQL does not carry a proprietary licence fee. It was also the possibility of reducing recurring Oracle expenditure and dependence on a single proprietary data-

base vendor.

Mr. Kiran made that broader argument in his IndiaFOSS presentation saying, "Every rupee spent on a proprietary database license is a rupee not spent on the public."

The team used Ora2Pg, an open-source tool created by Mr. Darold, to help convert the Oracle database to PostgreSQL.

Mr. Kiran said Ora2Pg automated roughly 60-70% of the migration. The remaining work required human intervention, including converting application code, validating data and tuning performance. The tool therefore did not make the migration automatic. Oracle-specific functions and other database constructs had to be examined and reworked. The team also had to validate that the PostgreSQL environment behaved as expected. The migration was carried out in phases. At one stage, the system wrote data to both Oracle and PostgreSQL, allowing the team to validate the new environment before the final switch.

Oracle was eventually decommissioned and PostgreSQL became the primary database. Mr. Kiran said the team had recorded zero incidents on the PostgreSQL database for two quarters after the migration.

India may be best placed to fill China's fuel void

Reuters
LITTLETON, COLORADO

China's decision to suspend fuel exports for October has raised fresh fears of a further tightening in global markets.

But a combination of rebounding crude oil imports and recent tax cuts on fuel exports makes India well-placed to fill the void.

India has the world's fourth-largest refinery system, with 23 refineries capable of processing roughly 5.6 million barrels per day (bpd) of crude oil, Indian state data show.

That refining footprint compares with more than 18 million bpd capacity in China and the US and roughly 6.7 million bpd of capacity in Russia, according to the Energy Institute, and traditionally makes India a key fuel supplier to a slew of Asian economies.

India is also the consistently larger fuel exporter compared to China, with India's combined shipments of diesel, gasoline and jet fuel hitting roughly 47 million metric tonnes in 2025 compared with China's 25.4 million tonnes, data from Kpler showed.



Slippery slope: Tugboats helping a crude oil tanker to berth at an oil terminal, off Waidiao Island in Zhoushan, China. REUTERS

However, India's combined exports of diesel, gasoline and jet fuel over the first nine months of 2026 have contracted by roughly 23%, or nearly 8 million metric tonnes, from a year earlier.

The US-Israeli war on Iran has triggered steep cuts to oil supplies from the Middle East since late February, while sparking fuel and oil rationing across most major economies -including India - for the past several months.

The Indian government also raised duties on fuel exports in the wake of the Iran war, ensuring that the country's refiners were dissuaded from shipping too

much fuel overseas while domestic supplies were at risk of depletion.

But the outlook for India's fuel exports is starting to brighten following two consecutive cuts to fuel-export taxes, which boost the appeal of steering more fuel onto the export arena.

Climbing crude imports

A steep rebound in Middle Eastern crude oil exports is likely a major driver behind the easing of India's fuel-export taxes.

India has traditionally sourced around 45% to 50% of its crude oil from the Middle East, with around 9.4 million metric tonnes of Middle Eastern

oil arriving in India each month in 2025, Kpler data showed. But the war in Iran, which kicked off in late February, resulted in India's average oil imports from the Middle East dropping to less than 6 million tonnes a month from March through July.

That in turn triggered a broader tightening in India's oil reserves and prompted stepped-up oil imports from other origins, which cost more and took longer to reach India's refineries.

Oil flows from the Middle East have now started to recover, however, with deliveries to India in September topping 11.3million tonnes, Kpler data showed.

That is India's highest monthly oil haul from the Middle East since February and has restored confidence among Indian officials that fuel exports can start to be elevated again.

Key destinations

The top destinations for Indian fuel exports in 2025 were the United Arab Emirates, Australia, Tanzania, Singapore and South Africa, Kpler data showed.

With tanker traffic

This is where the ₹10-crore figure needs to be understood carefully. Mr. Tirumala said Oracle licensing and maintenance had cost about ₹10 crore a year and that the migration would eliminate that recurring expenditure.

Mr. Darold, in his account of the project, put the previous Oracle licensing and maintenance cost at approximately \$1.2 million a year. He also said the migration cost cited by Mr. Tirumala was below \$120,000.

The ₹10 crore figure, therefore, refers to the reported annual Oracle licensing and maintenance expenditure that Telangana says it will no longer incur.

Was it risky?

The migration involved significant technical and administrative risks. Mr. Kiran said the project went through several steering committees because of the importance of MeeSeva, and that government officials had to be convinced that the migration could be carried out without disrupting citizen services.

The migration was completed with less than four hours of downtime, according to Mr. Tirumala and Mr. Darold. Downtime refers to the period during which the MeeSeva services were temporarily unavailable while the database was being migrated.

Mr. Kiran said the new architecture was designed for automatic failover, with a recovery time objective of about 30 seconds. In other words, if the primary database fails, the system can automatically switch to a backup, with the team targeting recovery within about 30 seconds.

The team did not simply replicate the existing Oracle architecture. Mr. Kiran said it initially considered doing so, but eventually redesigned and consolidated parts of the database architecture to work with PostgreSQL.

The Telangana experience does not mean that

every government system running on Oracle can immediately be moved to PostgreSQL.

Mr. Kiran said some MeeSeva services did not have staging environments, making conventional testing difficult. The team therefore had to simulate production conditions and conduct extensive validation before the final cutover. There was also a rollback plan in case the migration failed.

The experience therefore offers a more complicated lesson than simply choosing free software. It shows what can be involved in attempting to reduce dependence on a proprietary technology after years of use.

A cost-cutting tool?

Eliminating a proprietary database licence can reduce recurring technology expenditure. But the economics have to be evaluated over the entire life of the system.

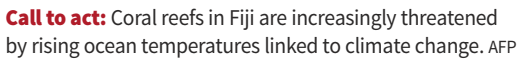
Migration itself costs money. Open-source systems require skilled personnel. Infrastructure, support and maintenance still have to be paid for. And the risk of moving a mission-critical system has to be weighed against the cost and risks of remaining with the existing technology.

Mr. Kiran argues that governments should examine their recurring proprietary software bills and assess whether open-source alternatives could perform the same functions. He pointed to government systems such as land records, tax, pensions, transport, health, education and citizen portals as examples of areas where proprietary database licences can form recurring costs.

For other governments, the lesson may be less about replacing proprietary software with open-source alternatives and more about examining whether proprietary technology remains worth its recurring cost and vendor dependence.

peated willingness to curb exports in favour of domestic energy security means that fuel importers can no longer assume Chinese barrels will be available when shortages emerge. India is increasingly offering an alternative. Its refiners are highly export-oriented, its links with Middle Eastern crude suppliers are strengthening again and policymakers now appear more comfortable with allowing a greater share of fuel production to reach global markets.

China's export suspension may prove temporary. The larger significance is that global fuel markets are being forced to identify who can step in when China steps back. With crude supplies recovering, export restrictions easing and spare refining capacity available, India looks better positioned than any other country to fill that role. For fuel consumers across Asia, that could make India more than just a major exporter. It could make India the new swing supplier that helps keep regional energy markets balanced during periods of disruption.



Agence France-Presse
NADI

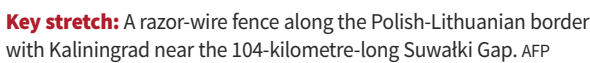
Fiji's Climate Minister Lynda Tabuya called for commitments from developing nations to a "just transition", with support for "countries in the world that suffer the most". A UN report released in August found developing countries needed \$310 billion-\$365 billion to adapt, yet had only \$26 billion in adaptation finance available in 2023.

Moscow has accused the alliance of increasing military pressure around the strategic exclave and has sent a formal diplomatic note to the NATO over what it sees as attempts to isolate the territory; however, NATO has rejected the accusations, saying its activities in the region are 'defensive'

Smriti Sudesh

Russia has accused the alliance of increasing military pressure around Kaliningrad and has sent a for-

It was formerly the German city of Königsberg and the capital of East Prussia.



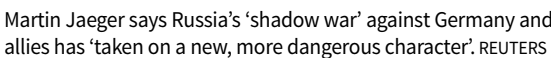
dent, Kaliningrad became an exclave. Today, around a million people live there.

Strategic importance

military position close to Poland, Lithuania, and the rest of NATO's eastern side. Russia has deployed air-defence systems, coastal-de-

Agence France-Presse
BERLIN

“No other country cur-



Germany has repeatedly

Berlin has invested record sums into rebuilding its military to deter Russia, and is among the largest supporters of Ukraine in its

Still, Mr. Jaeger called it “a grand illusion” to believe that Germany’s confrontation with Russia would be over if the war in Ukraine comes to an end.

Migrants shield themselves from the rain while queuing to charge their mobile phones at an NGO stand in Ceuta, Spain, on Monday. REUTERS

NEWS ANALYSIS

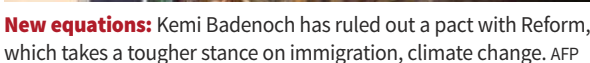
Agence France-Presse
BIRMINGHAM

But a decline in support for Reform as its leader Nigel Farage faces intense scrutiny over financial gifts sees Kemi Badenoch's Tories meet in Birmingham, central England, enjoying

It has won more general elections and returned the most Prime Ministers of any modern-day U.K. political party.

The Tories were in go-

The Conservatives' standing fell further in 2025 as Mr. Farage's hard-right upstarts opened up huge leads in opinion polls, with one survey suggesting the Tories could be



But a police investigation into allegations of illegal donations and a parliamentary sleaze probe into a £5-million (\$6.7-million) gift to Mr. Farage has dented the anti-immigration party's appeal.

Reform, which along with Mr. Farage denies wrongdoing, is also under pressure from Restore Britain, a party further to the right which has received the backing of U.S. tech billionaire Elon Musk.

“They’re doing better than they’ve done in the last year and a half. But they’re still about four points behind... (the 24% vote share) they had at the (2024) general election,” he said.

Right-wing vote 'split'
 "Their ratings have improved lately but mainly because Reform's have begun to drop."
 Ms. Badenoch, 46, has

"It would split the right-wing vote in a whole bunch of constituencies that Labour would then be able to hold on to," he said.

Men in Blue will look to rotate the players, says Morkel



Bowling coach Morkel all praise for rookie pacers Prince and Mayank



Kumkum and Sujeet named first winners of IOA awards



A good result is important as it builds confidence, says Jamil



West Indies could run India close in five-match T20I series

Akeal confident W Indies will push India

Need to strike a balance between continuity and exposure, says Morkel



India looks to bounce back as it faces the Uruguay test

India can hurt Uruguay if given time and space: Forlan

Jamil urges India to stay focused

"Against Uruguay, we have to start with good concentration and maintain it from the first minute till the end of the game. We have to believe that we can get a good result," he added.

‘Two bodies, one destiny’: Mukesh and Akash savour tight bond

The Rest of India fast bowlers — who have had eerily similar journeys from Bihar to the Indian team via Bengal — shared nine wickets among them to bowl out Jammu & Kashmir for 111 in the fourth innings at the Sher-i-Kashmir Stadium

IRANI CUP

Vivek Krishnan
SRINAGAR

When did Mukesh Kumar and Akash Deep meet for the first time? Neither seems to consider that relevant to the friendship. “Forget it. *Jab bhi mile hain, gale mile hain* (Whenever we have met, we have hugged each other),” Mukesh grinned after the pair starred in Rest of India’s victory over Jammu & Kashmir in the Irani Cup. Such is the bond of two fast bowlers who have had eerily similar journeys from Bihar to the Indian team via Bengal. At the Sher-i-Kashmir Stadium on Sunday, Mukesh (six for 33) and Akash (three for 25)

shared nine wickets among them to bowl out J&K for 111 in the fourth innings. “Whatever happens for us, it happens together. I don’t know what is written in our destiny,” Akash said. “The bodies are different, but our fate is the same. That’s why it is difficult to explain. We ourselves don’t know why everything happens alike for us.” For Akash, a bag of wickets in this fixture has added significance given he was coming back after a seven-month injury layoff. The 29-year-old touched speeds in excess of 140kmph right through. “My body needed a rest. God gave it to me in the form of an injury and I utilised it well. I am not putting in a lot of effort to bowl 140kmph-plus. This is the result of 6-7 months of training,” he noted.



Picture perfect: Rest of India pacers Mukesh, Akash and Mukesh Choudhary celebrate with the trophy. IMRAN NISSAR

J&K aims to iron out glitches for Ranji defence



Umar claimed five wickets but was also guilty of sending down 22 no-balls. IMRAN NISSAR

Vivek Krishnan
SRINAGAR

Jammu & Kashmir appeared to run out of steam against Rest of India towards the closing stages of the Irani Cup. It reflected in the 167-run margin of defeat. It should not overly perturb the reigning Ranji Trophy champion going into its title defence on October 11, given that the opposition had as many as six

players who have represented India in its ranks. On the contrary, the host did not have the services of star pacer Auqib Nabi who was part of India’s squad for the ODI series against the West Indies. With Paras Dogra & Co. facing Madhya Pradesh in their Ranji opener at the Sher-i-Kashmir Stadium, the 41-year-old stressed that there is only a need to fine-tune. “We fought really well

against a Rest of India team where there were six-seven India players,” Dogra said after the loss. “It’s a very good sign that we are there.” Dogra highlighted Umar Nazir’s 22 no-balls across the two innings as one area requiring work. “There were a few too many no-balls. Against such a big team, minor errors can lead to a loss. We will try to minimise those small mistakes,” the mid-

dle-order batter said. J&K didn’t have the pair of Nabi and Yudhvir Singh available, but the other fast bowlers showed they could deliver. **Learning a lot** “We learnt a lot of things from this game. A little about the batting and a little about the bowling. We have the strength, so we can also change a few bowlers if needed,” Dogra added.

Portugal, sans Ronaldo, seals last-eight berth



Decisive: Ramos’ strike helped Portugal overcome Norway and make the quarterfinals. GETTY IMAGES

NATIONS LEAGUE

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Portugal became the first team to reach the quarterfinals of the Nations League when it beat Norway 2-1 on Sunday, but Jurgen Klopp’s Germany was frustrated by Greece. The Portuguese showed that they did not need Cristiano Ronaldo, who walked out of the camp on Wednesday when coach Jorge Jesus relegated him to the bench.

Stunning opener

Goncalo Ramos secured victory in the 79th minute after Joao Cancelo’s powerful finish had levelled Kristoffer Ajer’s stunning opener from outside the penalty area for World Cup quarterfinalists Norway. After the game, Jesus said he was prepared to allow 41-year-old Ronaldo to return to the national team but that it would have to be the player’s decision.

“If he wants to, he’ll return to the national team... we can talk before the next call-up, but Cris is the one who’s going to decide,” Jesus told reporters. Germany held Jurgen Klopp’s Germany failed to break down a resolute Greek side in a goalless stalemate in Thessaloniki. Germany had the ball in the net through Eintracht Frankfurt forward Jonathan Burkardt in the first half but his effort was disallowed. Klopp’s record as new German boss now reads: lost one, won one, drawn one.

Zirkzee’s winner

The Netherlands beat Serbia 2-1, thanks to Joshua Zirkzee’s winner to move top of their Nations League group. The Manchester United forward was a second-half substitute in Eindhoven and applied the decisive touch with a tap-in from Tijjani Reijnders’ cross. The match also marked

Virgil van Dijk’s 100th international appearance. New Netherlands coach Xavi is unbeaten after four games, with two wins and two draws. Israel’s players wore black armbands in their 1-1 draw against Ireland to commemorate the victims of Hamas’ October 7, 2023 attack, after Irish players had worn them in the previous match in Hungary to protest the war in Gaza. Wales lost again, as Rasmus Hojlund slotted in a 75th minute penalty to earn Denmark a 1-0 win.

The results:
League A: Greece 0 drew with Germany 0; Netherlands 2 (Koopmeiners 31, Zirkzee 71) bt Serbia 1 (Cvetkovic 35). Portugal 2 (Joao Cancelo 38, Goncalo Ramos 79) bt Norway 1 (Ajer 36). Wales 0 lost to Denmark 1 (Hojlund 75-pen).
League B: Kosovo 1 (Asllani 70) drew with Austria 1 (Lang 85); Rep. of Ireland 1 (Parrott 39-pen) drew with Israel 1 (Peretz 47).
League D: Malta 1 (Teuma 49) bt Andorra 0; Azerbaijan 1 (Khaibulaev 25) bt Lithuania 0.

Chance for ‘A’ team players to stake claim in ODIs

Anish Pathiyil
PUDUCHERRY

In 366 days, India will step onto the park for its 2027 ODI World Cup opener against Australia in Cape Town, South Africa. The ‘A’ squads of both nations will contest a three-match one-day series starting at the Cricket Association of Pondicherry Stadium on Tuesday, hoping to book a ticket to the plateaus of southern Africa next year. The countdown to the global tournament will seem to be ticking faster for these players, as opportunities to stake a claim for selection diminish with each passing day. Both India and Australia have fairly settled squads in the 50-over format, leaving only a few spots up for grabs. The India-A squad for the one-dayers wears a similar look to the one that participated in a tri-series involving Afghanistan and Sri Lanka in June. Among those added was all-rounder Hardik Pandya. The series was a critical step to gauge his fitness ahead of the New Zealand tour later this month. But a reported shin injury has ruled him out. Mumbai’s Suryansh Shedge has been named his replacement. Jharkhand’s Anukul Roy has replaced Naman Dhir, who has been added to the squad for the West Indies T20Is. Only six players remain from the Australia-A side that lost the multi-day leg O-1 a few days ago. A fresh set of pacers will have the chance to improve their stocks ahead of a World Cup year. The first match of the one-day series will be a day-night contest, starting at 2 p.m.

Baloda leaves the Aussies in a bind



Wheeling away: Baloda’s toil reaped rich dividends. VIJAY SONEJI

AUS U-19 IN INDIA

Sahil Mathur
AHMEDABAD

Tanmay Baloda had a long, laborious day. The left-arm spinner bowled 25 overs, including 18 in his first spell. But it was all worth it when he leapt in joy after picking up a six-wicket haul on the opening day of the second youth Test between India under-19 and Australia under-19 here at the Narendra Modi Stadium on Monday. Baloda finished with six for 32 and helped the host bowl out the visitor for 174. India u-19 ended the day 136 runs behind, but lost openers Lakshya Raichandani and Sagar Virk to bring Australia back in the game. Baloda had taken centre stage earlier. The 18-year-old broke three acts of resistance from the Australians. The first came when Neel Patel (31) and Eli Brain put on 22 after Priyanshu Singh and

Mohit Ulva reduced Australia to 28 for two. Baloda immediately trapped Brain in front for four, and when Neel danced down the track, the wicketkeeper stumped him. From the other end, Ayaan Akram had Blake Cattle poking, while Baloda had Zed Hollick caught behind. After Australia lost four wickets inside five overs, Charlie Henderson (37) and Jacob Pietz (26) put up the second act. The duo, solid in defence, tested India’s patience, adding 70 runs off 242 deliveries for the seventh wicket. However, right after tea, Baloda broke through Pietz’ defence, and soon Akram had Henderson caught at first slip. But Australia fought back through Thomas Vaseo and Patrick Sullivan. Baloda, though, did what he had done throughout the day – break the tailenders’ resistance. **The scores:** Australia u-19 174 in 73 overs (Tanmay Baloda 6/32) vs. India u-19 38/2 in 15 overs. **Toss:** India.

Ahmedabad Marathon joins World Athletics Global Calendar

Press Trust of India
AHMEDABAD

The Adani Ahmedabad Marathon has been included in the World Athletics Global Calendar ahead of its 10th edition on November 29, making performances at the race eligible for consideration in World Athletics Rankings. The inclusion marks a significant milestone for the marathon, which has grown from a few thou-

sand runners in its early editions to more than 24,000 participants in its previous edition. The event has evolved into a city-wide sporting occasion, with runners, volunteers, families and Armed Forces personnel participating on the streets of Ahmedabad. The milestone comes as Ahmedabad prepares to host the 2030 Commonwealth Games, adding to the City’s growing sporting profile.

Smotherman clinches maiden PGA Tour title

GOLF

Agence France-Presse
LOS ANGELES

American golfer Austin Smotherman claimed the first PGA Tour victory of his career on Sunday, sealing a two-stroke triumph at the Bank of Utah Championship. Smotherman, 32, carded a closing three-under-par 68 at the Black Desert Resort in Ivins to finish on 25 under. That was good enough



Smotherman. GETTY IMAGES

for the World No. 121 to hold off Doug Ghim in second place, who shot a final-round 69 for a 24 under total. David Ford’s seven-under-par 64 left him tied for third with Trace Crowe.

Djokovic in final after Medvedev is defaulted

TENNIS

Associated Press
BEIJING

Daniil Medvedev was disqualified from his semifinal against Novak Djokovic at the China Open after he hit a ball into the stands that struck a spectator in the front row on Monday. The spectator was helped out of the arena holding a hand over his left eye. Djokovic was serving for the match at 7-5, 5-3 when Medvedev hit the ball into the stands in apparent frustration. The incident was reminiscent of when Djokovic was kicked out of the 2020 US Open for accidentally hitting a line judge in the throat with a ball. Djokovic extended his perfect career record at the China Open to 33-0. On Sunday, Djokovic rolled back the years to oust Alexander Zverev from the China Open on Sunday, beating the top seed 4-6, 6-4, 6-4. In Tuesday’s final, Djokovic will face ninth-ranked Alex de Minaur, who advanced when Hubert Hurkacz retired due to an apparent injury midway through the second set of their semifinal. De Minaur led 6-4, 3-2 when Hurkacz – who was barely able to run for balls in the second set – stopped playing. The nature of Hurkacz’s injury was not immediately clear. In the third round of the women’s tournament, which ends on Sunday, six-time Grand Slam champion Iga Swiatek rallied past Donna Vekic 4-6, 7-6 (0), 6-2 and will next meet Iva Jovic, who beat Kamilla Rakhimova 6-1, 7-5. Elina Svitolina beat Maria Sakkari 6-4, 7-5. US Open champion Elena Rybakina withdrew from the upcoming Wuhan Open due to a foot injury. On Saturday, Rybakina lost her first match with the No. 1 ranking when she was ousted in Beijing by No. 118 Alina Charaeva of Armenia in the second round while the second seed Aryna Sabalenka was ousted in the third round the next day. Charaeva extended her breakout run by beating Sonay Kartal 6-4, 6-1 to reach the last 16. Czech Nikola Pietrangola, 20, beat the former World No. 1 Sabalenka 6-4, 6-3 in little over an hour.



Freack incident: Djokovic was serving for the match when Medvedev hit the ball into the stands in frustration. REUTERS

